

THE HANDS OF GENOCIDE

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FADE IN:

INT. PUB - DAY

We focus on the front door. In the background, we can hear laughter and drunken yelling.

The door opens, and we see a WOMAN. Behind the Woman are three YOUNG MEN and a YOUNG WOMAN.

The Woman is an older woman, about 50s, with jet-black hair that touches the nape of her back. She wears an elegant silk dress that hides her feet, and a gold choker decorated with glimmering emeralds.

The first Young Man is dressed in a soldier's uniform, royal blue, black belt, leather boots, but he has the bearings of an aristocrat. He keeps his long hair straight and neatly trimmed.

The second Young Man is muscular but on the stocky side. Crazy eyes, blonde hair. Wears a posh suit and brass knuckles with the number "18" imprinted on them.

The third Young Man is the twin brother of the Young Woman. He wears a brown suit, keeps his hair tied up in a messy bun, and has dark and thoughtful eyes.

The Young Woman keeps her hair short. She's wearing a silk dress that stops above the knee. A female pocket watch dangles from her wrist.

The BARTENDER comes over to greet them, but before he can get a word out--

WOMAN
Table for five.

And before the Bartender can show them to a table--

WOMAN (CONT'D)
We'll seat ourselves.

The group of five walk OFF SCREEN.

CUT TO -

A view above the split-level pub. Made completely of wood.

On the bottom floor, near the entrance, is the bar. A bartender is filling sixteen beer steins from a keg.

On the top floor are tables and a second bar.

There's a table of sixteen armed soldiers, merrily drinking and shouting profanities at one another.

CUT TO -

A soldier named CARL BRAMSWORTH, 25, in the middle of the table of soldiers. He's more dainty than his company. Unblemished face, and a uniform that is just as clean.

The group of five comes up the stairs.

The soldiers whistle at the two women in the group.

The Older Woman and Bramsworth make eye contact.

Bramsworth gives her a knowing nod.

The group of five find a table in the corner, by the window.

The soldier sitting to Bramsworth's right, JIM, wraps his arm around Bramsworth's shoulder.

JIM
(to Bramsworth)
What's up, man?
(ref: full beer stein on
table)
You haven't even finished your
first drink.

RANDOM SOLDIER
(to Jim)
He doesn't want to mess up his
pretty shirt!

Laughter spreads across the table.

Bramsworth reluctantly chugs his drink.

JIM
(to Bramsworth)
Atta boy!

SOLDIERS
(chanting)
Another round!

They bang on the table with their hands.

The bartender makes several trips to bring the sixteen beer steins to the table.

The soldiers cheer.

They all chug their beers at the same time.

A soldier at the far end of the table bangs his empty beer stein on the table. Makes a beat.

The other soldiers follow his lead.

SOLDIERS (CONT'D)

(singing)

I drink and fuck and eat my fill,
and then the world is ripe for
peel!

The soldiers laugh.

Bramsworth gets up.

JIM

(to Bramsworth)

Don't tell me you're leaving!

BRAMSWORTH

(to Jim)

Bathroom.

Bramsworth goes to the bathroom.

Beat.

RANDOM SOLDIER 2

You all hear the latest rumor
running through the mill?

(no reply; beat)

A boy of thirteen was hand-picked
by the King himself to be in the
Royal Army.

RANDOM SOLDIER 3

(shock)

Thirteen?

(beat)

What could a boy that age know
about protecting the King? What
regiment was he from?

RANDOM SOLDIER 2

(to Random Soldier 3)

Well, rumor has it that the King
has been collecting the strongest
Gold Bloods from the ghettos to
make a personal army of wizards.

Random Soldier 3 spits on the floor.

RANDOM SOLDIER 3

The world has survived centuries
without magic. We don't need em.

(beat)

Allowing those people in here, if
that's what you want to call em, is
asking for trouble.

The Older Woman is staring daggers at the soldiers from
across the room.

WOMAN

(to Wild Man; low)

Get the door.

He gets up and heads for the door.

We can hear the Wild Man and the bartender arguing.

A distinctive THUD. Someone's dead.

The soldiers quiet down. One of them gets up and heads for
the stairs.

The Bun Guy with the thoughtful eyes gets up and blocks the
stairs.

RANDOM SOLDIER 3

(to Bun Guy)

What the fuck is this?

(beat)

Don't you know who we are?

OLDER WOMAN

(to Soldier 1)

It doesn't matter who you are,
little man.

RANDOM SOLDIER 3

(to Long-hair Soldier)

Who are you?

The Long-hair Soldier gets up from the table. Stands beside
the Older Woman.

LONG-HAIR SOLDIER

Thaal Ardenhart. Fifth Regiment.

RANDOM SOLDIER 3

Get your woman before she gets into
trouble.

(to Woman)

You hear that?

(MORE)

RANDOM SOLDIER 3 (CONT'D)
 Run your mouth again and I'll carve
 you up and use your tendons as a
 cock-ring while I fuck your cold
 cunt.

The Long-hair soldier, Bun Guy, and Pocket Watch Twin pull
 out old and gnarled wands.

The soldiers stand up and draw their guns.

OLDER WOMAN
 (cocky)
 I've heard it said that a true
 soldier will always trudge forward,
 even to a battle he knows he cannot
 win. That a true warrior is not
 afraid to knock on Death's door.
 (beat)
 Are any of you men afraid to die?

RANDOM SOLDIER 4
 In Petrapolis we only have one God,
 Old Man Death himself. We have
 nothing to fear from the only God
 we know.

OLDER WOMAN
 Give him my regards.

EXT. PRADRAKAIN FESTIVAL - SAME

Hog Hollow Road runs through the entirety of the city-state
 Petrapolis. Today, it hosts the Pradrakoin Festival, the
 Petrapolian New Year celebration.

Food stands line the street, serving the traditional meals of
 more countries than can be counted on two hands.

The city itself is the Middle Ages meets 20th-century
 poverty.

In the background of everything...a herculean palace of white
 stone...the ROYAL PALACE. A mile away...a large temple made
 of obsidian...the DEATH TEMPLE.

CUT TO -

A group that stands out in the crowds of people meandering
 through the festival:

AXL ARDENHART, 20s. Dressed in dowdy clothes that draw the
 eye away from his handsome face. He has pitch-black irises
 that cause the passersby to keep a good distance from him.

PARIS, 20s. Fair, and beautiful. Her style of dress could be called "semi-post-apocalyptic" professional chic.

SILOS & MORA ARDENHART, 10s. Twins. Dirty clothes, shoes on the verge of falling apart. Silos is autistic.

This group could be confused for a family.

PARIS

Imagine my surprise when Axl Ardenhart left a note in my school bag inviting me to the Pradrakoin Festival.

(whimsical)

Flattered, I am.

AXL

I wanted to take you out.

(beat; reluctant)

And, maybe, make up for the other day.

PARIS

"Maybe," he says.

(beat)

We could've gone to one of our usual, more discreet hang-outs.

AXL

I specifically wanted to come here.

(beat)

Because--

PARIS

Because...

AXL

Because you were right.

(reluctant)

I am ashamed. But, it's not you; it's me. I mean, look at me.

Axl pulls at his clothes.

AXL (CONT'D)

And then look at you. So beautiful, and perfect.

Paris flashes a smile.

PARIS

I don't care about that. Things will get better for us.

(MORE)

PARIS (CONT'D)
And even if they don't, I'll still
be Mrs. Paris Ardenhart one day.

Paris kisses Axl on the cheek.

Silos and Mora giggle.

PARIS (CONT'D)
(to Silos & Mora)
What's so funny, you two?

SILOS
(to Paris)
You're gonna have a baby!

Paris laughs nervously.

Mora spots a nougat stand up the street.

MORA
(pointing; to Silos)
Candy!

Paris fishes out some cash from her pocket. Hands it Mora.

PARIS
(to Mora)
Don't spend it all on candy!

Mora and Silos run toward the stand.

SILOS
(running; to Mora)
We'll always be together, no matter
what!

Axl and Paris slow down.

PARIS
I wonder if this is what it feels
like to be married. Can you imagine
us with a house of our own?

AXL
Can Ox stay in the basement?

PARIS
(laughing)
Only if Betty can stay upstairs.

AXL
Sebastian will probably have a
house of his own, twice as big.

PARIS

That's fine with me. It'll be us
and the twins on the main
floor...and maybe with two little
ones of our own.

AXL

(annoyed)

We've talked about this.

PARIS

I just don't see why--

AXL

Because I don't. Okay?

Awkward silence.

AXL (CONT'D)

I can't have kids because I'm a
monster. I don't want my children
to have these eyes. It's easy for
you to prance around, telling to
the world to fuck off because you
"love me anyway." But imagine, for
one second, how you'll feel when
your children can't even walk down
the street without being stared at?

Paris looks at the passersby. They're obviously afraid of
Axl.

AXL (CONT'D)

When other parents pick up their
children and run away from the very
sight of them. When your own
people, who should be the most open-
minded of all, see you as nothing
more than a leashed beast.

Axl wipes tears from his eyes.

AXL (CONT'D)

You don't know what it's like to be
different from everyone. To truly
be alone in the world.

They stop right in front of the pub.

Paris hugs Axl.

Paris pulls away from Axl, holds her stomach.

PARIS
(sheepish)
Well, I hate to be the bearer of
bad news.

CUT TO:

EXT. PUB - SAME

We see an owl sitting on the roof of the pub. It's watching Axl and Paris.

Paris is telling Axl something.

Axl looks surprised but worried.

Axl pulls Paris into another hug.

Long pause, then an antique store catches Paris' eye.

They go into the store.

The owl spreads its wings, about to fly.

CUT TO:

INT. ANTIQUE STORE - SAME

Axl isn't impressed by the store. It's not at all what he expected.

The floors are filthy; there's a musty odor hanging about the room, something uncharacteristic of this side of town.

There are paintings, typewriters, guns, furniture, statuettes. Generic trinkets that could possibly pass as Old World family heirlooms, but nothing appears to be particularly valuable.

Paris pokes around the shop nonplussed.

Meanwhile, Axl is seemingly waiting for something to jump out at him.

PARIS (O.C.)
Axl!

Axl startles but relaxes once he realizes it's Paris waving him over to a small display case in the corner of the store.

PARIS (CONT'D)
(impatient)
Come here!

Axl joins her.

Inside the display case is a wand propped up on a silk pillow. It's dowdy and well-used. A long life of rebounding spells has caused the wand to become gnarled and knotted like the wands we saw being used in the pub.

SHOP-OWNER (O.C.)
(annoyed)
Can I help you?

The SHOP-OWNER, 40s, is a rotund man dressed like the typical aristocrat in Petrapolis, in clothes made with materials that cost more to procure than the wages paid to those who sewed them. Despite his posh disposition, he's intimidating.

Neither Axl nor Paris heard the Shop Owner come up the stairs. It's as if he appeared before them.

SHOP-OWNER (CONT'D)
(stern)
We're not open for business.

The Shop-Owner's rigid face softens once he notices Axl's eyes.

SHOP-OWNER (CONT'D)
(cheerful)
Oh, but do help yourselves to a preview. I insist.

Beat, then he approaches Axl. Leans in close.

SHOP-OWNER (CONT'D)
(to Axl)
I know what it is that has captured your curiosity.

The Shop-Owner unlocks the display case. Carefully takes out the wand.

He presents the wand to Axl.

SHOP-OWNER (CONT'D)
It is said that the wand will choose its true master before the reverse could ever occur. Like a marriage, it is. The wand, in the hands of the unchosen, will inevitably act out.
(MORE)

SHOP-OWNER (CONT'D)

Like a captured animal, scratching
away at its cage.

(to Axl)

As you can probably tell, this wand
has seen many hands and has had a
tendency to nip at its many
handlers over the years. Sadly, a
wand, even in the custody of an
unchosen wizard, is tethered to its
master. And when it attacks, it
damages itself in the process. It
would rather risk death than to
submit to a false master. Rather
touching, isn't it?

PARIS

(to Shop-Owner)

Where did you--

SHOP-OWNER

(to Axl)

I believe I left the front door
locked. And yet, here you are.

(beat)

Why do you think that is?

Axl is too frightened to answer.

SHOP-OWNER (CONT'D)

(to Axl)

It seems you've been chosen.

INT. PUB - DAY

The Older Woman and her motley crew are sitting at the bar
having drinks.

The Wild Man is behind the bar compulsively cleaning a glass.

The corpses of the soldiers and the pub's staff litter the
floor.

Bramsworth comes up to the bar.

WILD MAN

(to Bramsworth)

Want anything?

BRAMSWORTH

I'll pass.

(to Older Woman)

Are we ready?

The Older Woman finishes her drink. Slams the glass down.

INT. ANTIQUE STORE

Axl reaches out and touches the wand, but recoils.

AXL

(to Shop-owner)

We're not allowed to own wands in the city.

PARIS

(to Axl)

So? No one has to know. If he's selling, we can buy.

SHOP-OWNER

(to Paris)

When did I say it was for sale?

(to Axl)

Dear boy, taking this wand will not incriminate you. The law says that the Gold Bloods are not permitted to use magic on these lands. Merely owning a wand doesn't imply that you have or will use magic. And what is a wand but a conduit for what is already resting inside of you?

Axl reluctantly plucks the wand from the pillow. He admires it.

SHOP-OWNER (CONT'D)

(to Axl)

It becomes you.

AXL

(to Shop-owner)

What does?

SHOP-OWNER

(to Axl)

Power.

The Older Woman from the pub can be heard screaming outside in the street.

OLDER WOMAN (O.C.)

Help! Help!

(screaming)

They've killed them all!

Axl hides the wand on his person, and then he and Paris head outside.

EXT. FESTIVAL - CONTINUOUS

The Older Woman is in the middle of the street.

A passerby wraps her in a blanket as she cries and shakes.

OLDER WOMAN

They appeared out of nowhere,
cloaked in darkness and chanting
the Oracle's prayer. One by one,
they slaughtered all of them right
in front of them.

MALE PASSERBY

(to Raven Woman)
Who? Who did it?

The Older Woman looks right at Axl.

OLDER WOMAN

Gold Bloods!

CUT TO -

A view above Hog Hollow Road.

The entire street has erupted into chaos.

People clamor to grab their things and run home.

Looters have started destroying the stands and stealing
whatever they can find.

Soldiers try to restore order, but they can barely contain
the mayhem.

The soldiers have begun to detain people at random.

They roll up their sleeves, check their arms. Anyone marked
with the alchemic symbol for gold is arrested.

CUT TO -

- Axl & Paris standing in front of the antique store.

AXL

(to Paris)
We have to find the twins.

PARIS
 (pointing down the street)
 They went that way.

They run, full speed.

THE NOUGAT STAND -

The stand has been looted and knocked over.

Silos and Mora have been detained by a male soldier.

In the background we see other soldiers detaining people at random, threatening them with their guns.

FEMALE SOLDIER (O.C.)
 Everyone stay where you are!

The soldier detaining Silos and Mora rolls their sleeves up, revealing their tattoos.

MALE SOLDIER
 (to Other Soldiers)
 I got two of them right here!
 (to Silos and Mora)
 You two are coming with me!

Silos and Mora struggle to get away from the soldier.

Silos shrieks uncontrollably.

Axl and Paris arrive on the scene. They spot Silos and Mora.

Axl is seething with rage, but doesn't move. He doesn't know what to do. *I have to help them, right?*

Axl pulls out his new wand and aims it at the soldier taking Silos and Mora away.

He's shaking and isn't gripping the wand properly.

All nearby soldiers aim their guns at Axl.

AXL
 (to Male Soldier)
 Let them go right now!

Male Soldier turns around. Sizes up Axl.

MALE SOLDIER
 (to Axl)
 Just calm down.
 (MORE)

MALE SOLDIER (CONT'D)
We're not here to hurt anyone. We
have orders to get you guys back
home safely.

AXL
You mean those fucking huts you
keep us in.

MALE SOLDIER
Beggars can't be choosers. If it
weren't for us and our King, you'd
all be corpses in that hell hole
you came from.
(beat; to Paris)
You. I know you. I know your
father.
(ref: Axl)
Tell him to calm down.

PARIS
(to Male Soldier)
Just let them come with us. They're
just kids.

MALE SOLDIER
(to Paris)
They're all just kids until you're
on the business end of their shiny
sticks.

Distracted by the conversation, Axl doesn't notice a soldier
sneaking up on him and Paris.

Sneaky Soldier tackles Paris to the ground.

MALE SOLDIER (CONT'D)
(to Other Soldiers)
Go!

Soldiers shoot at Axl from all directions. His black ink-
colored blood flies in all directions. He goes down.

PARIS
(aghast)
No!

Two female soldiers carry away Silos and Mora as they scream
and shout.

The soldier holding Paris down drags her off the scene.

Male Soldier goes to inspect Axl's body. Checks him for a
tattoo. Doesn't find one.

MALE SOLDIER
(to Other Soldiers)
This one doesn't have a tattoo!

RANDOM SOLDIER
Check his chest!

The other soldiers are annoyed with Male Soldier. They all return to hunting down more wizard refugees, leaving him to deal with Axl's corpse alone.

MALE SOLDIER
(annoyed; to Himself)
I'm going to be knee-deep in
paperwork over this shit.

Male Soldier kneels down to get closer to Axl.

Axl's eyes snap open. His sclerae have turned pitch-black, matching his irises.

Axl's wand, still in his hand, transforms into a was-scepter. It has a jade shaft tipped with a lion's head and a crescent made of ebony at the bottom.

Before the soldier can react, Axl stabs him with the crescent end of the wand.

Male Soldier is paralyzed. Eyes roll to the back of his head.

Noticing the commotion, the other soldiers nearby empty their clips into Axl and Male Soldier fearing Axl will continue to fight.

Axl and Male Soldier both collapse.

EXT. ORARO GHETTO - NIGHT

- A view of the ghetto.

Rows of unfinished and badly deteriorated micro houses made of wood and leftovers from other construction projects.

A courtyard in the center of the ghetto hosts a small communal oven, showers, and leads to the gate, which is the only entrance and exit, that is heavily guarded by armed soldiers.

CLOSE ON a guy sitting on the ground smoking a badly rolled cigarette.

This is OX, the second oldest of Axl's cousins. He's very much the spitting image of his namesake. Stocky, and muscular.

He finishes his smoke and goes inside one of the micro houses.

INT. ARDENHART HOUSE - CONTINUOUS

Studio. Could collapse at any moment. Cracks run through the walls.

The wooden floor is littered with holes and layers of filth. No furniture, save for a mattress and a couch.

SEBASTIAN, second youngest before the twins, is looking out the window. He's slim, on the short side. Dirty blonde and light eyes, whereas every other Ardenhart we've seen, excluding Axl, has black hair and brown eyes.

BETTY, dark-skin, athletic frame. Consoles Silos, whose crying uncontrollably in her arms.

Mora is on the couch, which is no doubt home to many pests, in the fetal-position.

Ox takes a seat on the couch.

Silos is calming down.

BETTY
(to Silos)
Do you want something to eat?

Silos nods.

Betty retrieves a tray of food from the other side of the house. Sausage, mashed potatoes, and very old carrots.

Betty sets the tray on the floor.

Silos and Mora eat directly from the tray.

BETTY (CONT'D)
(to Ox & Sebastian)
Dinner, guys.

SEBASTIAN
(looking outside)
Not hungry.

OX
(pinching the bridge of
his nose)
I'll pass.

BETTY
(to Ox)
Are you coming tonight?

OX
(to Betty)
No.

BETTY
(to Sebastian)
What about you?

SEBASTIAN
(to Betty)
Maybe.

BETTY
It'll look bad if we don't show up.

OX
(to Betty)
It won't make a difference whether
we show up or not, it's all
pointless.

BETTY
Ox, the Last Lighting is a
tradition!

OX
And?
(beat)
We've gotten to the point where we
have at least one every few days.
We might as well just get it over
with and have one for everyone that
lives here.

BETTY
Don't say that!

OX
Why? Because it's true?
(beat)
Give me one name. I want to hear
the name of any one person that has
stopped by to give their
condolences.
(no reply)
(MORE)

OX (CONT'D)
Exactly. Zero. That's because we
all know before it's all said and
done we're all going to die with
the rest of us of our people.
There's no point in honoring the
dead. There's no point in fighting
for justice.

Ox pulls up his sleeve, showing his tattoo.

OX (CONT'D)
We've already been marked for
slaughter.

Betty puts her shoes on.

BETTY
(defeated; to Ox)
I'm going. I can't just sit here
after what they did to Axl.

OX
(to Betty)
If you go and wind up getting hurt,
it'll be your own damn fault.

Betty leaves.

OX (CONT'D)
(to Sebastian)
Why don't you get some sleep? It's
your turn to sleep in the bed
tonight.

Sebastian nods. Lays down on the mattress.

Silos and Mora are still eating.

Silos picks up a piece of sausage. Just before he reaches his
mouth, he drops it.

Turns his head toward the window. He hears something.

Silos gets up and slowly approaches the window. He's afraid.

Silos hears gunshots and screaming. No one else in the
apartment hears anything.

OX (CONT'D)
(to Silos)
What is it?

Silos looks out the window:

There are soldiers sweeping through the ghetto, killing any wizard and non-magic refugees on sight.

The ground is wet with fresh ichor (golden blood) and blood.

They finish sweeping through the area Silos can see from the window.

In the distance, a lone figure stands amongst the many corpses. Tall, brooding and dressed in a black cloak.

The figure removes his hood. It's DEATH, 20s, debonair, coal-black hair.

Death smiles and waves at Silos.

Silos jumps back. Tears up.

OX (CONT'D)
(angry; to Silos)
What is it?

Silos looks at Ox. Blank expression.

SILOS
(to Ox)
We're all going to die.

EXT. ORARO GHETTO - LATER

VIGIL -

A circle of white candles in the courtyard. In the center is a single black candle.

The refugees stand a few feet away from the circle.

An elderly man steps forward to speak.

ELDER
We've gathered here today to send
our blessings to a kindred soul who
has passed on beyond the veil on
this day. We do this in the manner
our parents taught us, and their
parents before them. Just as the
Oracle laid out these guidelines to
the founders of our home across the
ocean, Aurates.
(beat)
We come from a proud stock.
(MORE)

ELDER (CONT'D)

A class of people that transcends race and old world patriotism. Aurates was once a beacon in a dark world for those of us with gold blood. And, eventually, it became a home to those non-wizards who wished not to harm us, but to join us and participate in our culture in their own way.

(beat)

It is from that stock and that once great nation from which Axl Ardenhart hailed from. And it is with a heavy heart that he will not be with us when Aurates is freed from the clutches of evil, and we return home to our lands.

The Elder goes into the crowd and ushers out a crying Betty.

ELDER (CONT'D)

In accordance with tradition, one of the next of kin to the deceased must pinch out of the flames of every candle in the circle, without magic. By doing this, she will take on some of the pain Axl Ardenhart endures on his long journey through the underworld.

Betty starts pinching out the candles in the circle one-by-one.

When she finishes, she returns to the crowd.

ELDER (CONT'D)

The last candle, in the center of the circle, shall stay lit as long as nature allows. As you all know, the longer it stays lit, the easier Axl's journey will be.

(beat)

Let us, for a moment, say a silent prayer to the Oracle that she may send good fortune to the soul of our fallen brother.

JUST OUTSIDE OF THE GHETTO -

A tall metal gate secured with barb wire and iron chains is all that separates the refugees from the rest of Petrapolis.

The gate is being guarded by fifteen, heavily armed soldiers.

Paris comes strolling up to the soldiers. Dressed in black with a bouquet of black roses.

RANDOM SOLDIER 5
(to Paris)
Stop right there.

PARIS
I just came to--

RANDOM SOLDIER 5
I don't care what you came for. You
aren't getting in.

Paris approaches the gate.

Random Soldier 5 pushes her away.

Paris slaps Random Soldier 5 with the bouquet. Scratching his face.

Black roses fly everywhere.

RANDOM SOLDIER 6
(to Random Soldier 5)
I've had enough of this shit. Those
fuckers in there went on a killing
spree today. If she wants to be one
of them, let her rot in a grave
with the rest of them.

Random Soldier 5 grabs Paris by the hair. Slams her to the floor. Pulls his gun out and presses it to the back of Paris' head.

Paris is crying. Starts screaming.

RANDOM SOLDIER 7
(to Random Soldier 5)
Wait! Wait! That's Earl
Brightworth's daughter!

Random Soldier 5 backs off immediately.

Paris gets up. She's injured. Broken nose, twisted ankle.

Having noticed the commotion, the refugees on the other side of the gate shout profanities at the soldiers.

The refugees start throwing rocks at the soldiers.

Betty backs away from the group.

Paris limps away to safety.

Random Soldier 6 bangs on the gate with his gun.

RANDOM SOLDIER 6
Enough al--

An arrow pierces his head. He falls to the ground. Dead.

The other soldiers open fire through the gates.

Betty tries to run, trips. Looks back.

The soldiers are opening the gate.

INT. ARDENHART APARTMENT - SAME

Ox, Sebastian, Mora, and Silos are running around the apartment grabbing anything that might be useful or valuable.

Lighters, rope, canned foods, meats and fruit.

They pack two backpacks full, then head out the door.

EXT. ORARO GHETTO - CONTINUOUS

As they exit outside, a soldier a few feet away shoots at them.

They all hit the ground, with only the cover of darkness protecting them.

The soldier is reloading his gun.

Ox and Sebastian look at each other. Ox nods.

Sebastian digs a white bearded dragon out his pant leg, and a wand, which strongly resembles Axl's wand, from his sleeve.

Sebastian taps the bearded dragon with his wand and then throws the animal a good distance away.

In mid-air, the bearded dragon transforms into a full-fledged dragon of juvenile size.

The soldier is stunned. He hasn't finished reloading.

The dragon looms over him, angry.

The soldier drops everything and runs.

The dragon releases a powerful flamethrower, burning the soldier to a crisp.

CUT TO -

- Bramsworth skulking about the ghetto dressed in dirty clothes typical of the refugees, wielding a bow.

Bloody corpses lay everywhere. He seems pleased with the sight.

A noise catches his attention. He tracks down the source of the disturbance.

A boy with a horribly broken leg laying on his belly is playing with a stick and one of Paris' black roses.

He taps the black rose with the stick. The rose turns blue.

We hear gunfire in the distance.

CUT TO -

- The remaining soldiers that were guarding the ghetto trying to shoot down Sebastian's dragon.

Ox, Sebastian, Silos, and Mora are running around looking for Betty while the soldiers are distracted.

OX

Betty!

(no reply; worried)

Betty!

Ox is on the verge of tears.

They all call Betty's name, except Silos.

SILOS

(to Ox)

We have to go! She's dead!

(beat)

I saw it! Everyone was dead!

OX

(to Silos)

I'm not leaving her!

Sebastian's legs give out. He's breathing hard.

In turn, the dragon shrinks a little.

SEBASTIAN

(to Ox)

I'm getting tired.

OX
(to Sebastian)
Just another minute.

Ox looks around. Stares at all the dead bodies scattered throughout the ghetto. Then looks back at Silos' dirty face.

Ox picks Sebastian up and heads for the dragon.

OX (CONT'D)
(to Silos & Mora)
Come on!

Silos and Mora follow.

SEBASTIAN
(to Dragon)
Rys!

Rys bats away the soldiers with ease. Then lowers his body for the group to climb onto his back.

Once they're all on securely, they take off into the sky.

CUT TO -

- THE VIGIL

Corpses and blood everywhere.

CLOSE ON the black candle. The flame burns strong.

Long pause, then it extinguishes itself.

EXT. SKY - DAY

ABOVE PETRAPOLIS -

We're high enough that we can see the entire layout of the city.

A tall electrified gate surrounds the entire city.

Everything outside of the gate is known as the Wastelands, a collective of former sovereign States on the island of Petrapolis.

The individual States are unofficially referred to as Dead Tip, The Desert Town of Kheeter and the Screaming Woods.

SCREAMING WOODS -

Ox, Sebastian, Silos, and Mora are still flying on Rys.

They're vigilant but fatigued.

Rys is slowly transforming back into his bearded dragon form.

Slowly descending. Now hovering just above the ground in a heavily wooded area.

A cabin comes into view.

SEBASTIAN
(to Rys)
Just a little more.

Rys hits a tree and reverts to his bearded dragon form.

The group is sent flying to the ground. They all land relatively close to each other.

They're too exhausted to move. They rest wherever they've fallen.

INT. PRISON - DAY

We're in the entryway of the prison. Concrete floors and walls caked with grime, blood, and other fluids.

A man and woman stand in front of the front doors.

The woman is DARI, 30s, the director the prison. She's dressed in Petrapolis' military uniform.

The man is ANA, late 20s, mid-length black hair, flamboyant. Also wearing the military uniform, but with a fancy jacket.

ANA
You seem to have a bit of stage
fright, my friend.

DARI
Nonsense.
(beat)
Did you gather every last one of
them?

ANA
Only the ones I knew would survive.

DARI
And what of our friend?

ANA

I'll be checking on him as soon as we're done here.

DARI

Any word on the wand?

ANA

The last test ended with failure, and the death of four of our top picks from the last bunch of recruits.

DARI

Continue the experiment.

ANA

We'll be short on good men sooner than later.

DARI

Are you expecting someone to attack us?

ANA

No. But--

DARI

Then I don't expect us to be needing any good men for combat anytime soon.

ANA

(whimsical)

The King wouldn't be too pleased to hear you talking like that.

DARI

The King doesn't run this prison. I do. You'll continue the experiment, and the next test subject will be at your discretion.

ANA

I still think it'd be wise to preserve our men.

DARI

I disagree. If you're so desperate for more capable fighters, then you'd better hope that this group of recruits is stronger than the last one you brought in.

Dari goes to open the door but stops.

DARI (CONT'D)
By the way, I've heard some
disturbing reports.

ANA
Do go on.

DARI
I've been hearing there's someone
of your particular talent running
amok in the city.

ANA
Oh? I wouldn't know anything about
it.

DARI
That phrase seems to have become
your motto as of late.

Dari opens the door.

EXT. PRISON - SAME

A view of the Prison.

Surrounded by the Screaming Woods on all sides, the prison is
within a perimeter of iron gates wrapped in barbed wire.

The main building, made of concrete and brick, is the actual
prison. Beside it is a smaller building made of the same
material, the infirmary.

In the four corners of the prison grounds are wooden forts,
which serve as homes and workstations for the snipers.

CUT TO -

- MAIN BUILDING

Dari and Ana step outside onto the stairs of the main
building.

There are two soldiers on either side of the stairs standing
at attention.

A group of the survivors from the Oraro ghetto is at the
bottom of the stairs. Betty is amongst them.

Soldiers surround the survivors, guns aimed at them.

DARI
 (to Survivors)
 I am Dari, the director of Prison
 Five.

There's a heckler in the group of survivors, an older woman -

HECKLER WOMAN
 (to Dari)
 And what have you brought us here
 for? We've done nothing wrong!

DARI
 (to Heckler Woman)
 Mind your tongue and speak when
 spoken to.
 (to Survivors)
 You're all here for disobeying the
 laws that our King, his Highness,
 have laid out for us.

HECKLER WOMAN
 And what law is that? You can't
 just shoot us down and drag us to
 this place without a trial!

Dari turns to the soldier standing to her right -

DARI
 (to Soldier)
 Shoot her down.

The soldier draws his gun, fires a shot at the Heckler Woman.

Betty jumps in front of the Heckler Woman. Holds her hands
 up.

The bullet stops mid-air.

Betty re-directs the bullet to the soldier who shot it.

The bullet stops just short of the soldier's head. The man
 doesn't even flinch...It's Thaal.

The bullet falls to the ground.

HECKLER WOMAN
 Magic without a wand. You've got a
 full blood in your ranks. I've
 heard the rumors of our own joining
 up with the same people that want
 to see us all dead.
 (to Soldiers)
 (MORE)

HECKLER WOMAN (CONT'D)
Shame on any of you with gold blood
who dare to side with our enemies.

DARI
(to Heckler Woman)
We are not your enemy.
(beat; to Survivors)
We granted you people asylum in our
country to shield you all from the
civil war in your country. A war
that made entire towns disappear in
a single night. We allow your
children into our schools so that
one day they can become productive
members of our society. And we only
asked of you one thing, leave your
wands at the door. All of you
before me have been convicted of
unlawfully using magic on our
lands, and all of you have been
found guilty. Those of you who do
not agree with our judgment should
not fret. Most of you won't make it
into the door.

Dari snaps her fingers.

The soldiers surrounding the survivors cock their guns.

DARI (CONT'D)
Here and now, you'll fight for a
spot within our prison. The rest of
you will be left out here to die,
or worse.

Shocked and worried expressions spread across the faces of
the survivors.

DARI (CONT'D)
You'll fight to the death. Only the
survivors will be permitted to
enter.

The survivors look around, hesitantly.

Dari snaps her fingers again.

A soldier shoots a young man in the chest.

The young man hits the ground. Ichor pools up around him as
the final death throes kick in.

DARI (CONT'D)
Will you fight, or die?

Beat, then chaos erupts within the group of survivors.

They start beating each other senseless.

The oldest and frail women are the first to go down.

A lanky man attacks Betty. Gets her on her back. Pummels her face.

Betty manages to flip him over onto his back and crush his windpipe with her knee.

Another challenger approaches. A male, close to her age. Kicks her in the head.

Betty hits the ground. Recovers. Kick sweeps the young man. Jumps up. Breaks his arm.

Betty's disposition changes to that of a wild animal.

She attacks a fearful girl around her age. Knocks her to the ground and starts kicking her in the rib cage.

The girl quickly yields, prompting Betty to prowl for her next victim.

HOLD ON Ana. He's pleased with Betty's performance.

Dari holds her hands up.

DARI (CONT'D)

Stop!

The survivors stop.

DARI (CONT'D)

(to Survivors)

All who stand may enter.

(beat)

The rest of you, this is where you sleep. Pray for a quick death.

Dari enters the prison.

The losers who are still conscious look around at what will be their new home.

The soldiers on the stairs march down to collect the victors.

Ana waltzes down the stairs, heading for the infirmary.

INT. INFIRMARY - SAME

Like the main prison, the floor and walls are caked with gunk of all sorts.

Ana saunters down the hall and enters a door to his left.

ROOM -

The room is cleaner than the rest of the infirmary but is still unsanitary enough to turn a stomach.

Axl is lying on a cot, naked, in the center of the room. His body is immaculate, as though he'd never been shot.

Ana caresses Axl's face.

A DOCTOR, 50s, enters.

ANA

Doctor Villa, how is our friend here?

DOCTOR VILLA

The same as yesterday.

(beat)

We pulled the last of the bullets ourselves. And just as you predicted, the wounds closed on their own.

ANA

But you still hold onto the theory that the boy is indeed dead?

DOCTOR VILLA

No pulse. Rigor mortis has set. What would you call it?

ANA

Magic.

DOCTOR VILLA

Well, look. I'm not well-versed in any magical arts. Some of the bodies you bring me turn to dust. Others catch on fire. Some don't show any signs of decomposition at all, and probably walk off into the night.

(beat)

(MORE)

DOCTOR VILLA (CONT'D)

Or, maybe, one of our "soldiers" as you call them steal them and fuck them for all I know. The point is, if each one of these things came with a manual, I'd be able to give you a concrete answer. But they don't, and I can't. As far as I can tell you, he's dead.

ANA

You know, if you weren't our only doctor, I'd kill you.

DOCTOR VILLA

I'm not the only doctor in this country.

ANA

But you are the only one with your particular talent.

Ana goes to the door. Opens it.

DOCTOR VILLA

A wise man once told me that talent is common.

ANA

(leaving)

You shouldn't be in such a rush to die.

Ana closes the door.

DOCTOR VILLA

(to Himself; low)

Death awaits us all with open arms.

EXT. PRISON - SAME

Ana looks around. Makes eye contact with a soldier nearby. Then heads inside the prison.

We hold on that soldier. It's Thaal.

One of his fellow soldiers approaches him. This soldier has dilated pupils.

Before the soldier can get a word out -

THAAL

I know it's you. Exactly how many puppets do you have?

PUPPET SOLDIER

We are many.

The Puppet Soldier whips out a pink cigarette. Lights it.
Start smoking.

THAAL

Do you keep smokes on all of your
puppets?

PUPPET SOLDIER

Working here is dreadfully boring
business.

THAAL

Then why work here?

PUPPET SOLDIER

I'm needed here.

(beat)

I should ask you the same question.
Why are you here?

THAAL

Just like you, I'm needed here.

PUPPET SOLDIER

You must be so pleased with
yourself. Becoming such a high-
ranking soldier in a short amount
of time is no easy feat.

In the background, we see one of the soldiers fighting with
one of the female survivors of Oraro. He's going to rape her
in front of everyone.

PUPPET SOLDIER (CONT'D)

(ref: rape)

Does that anger you? To see your
people reduced to such a state. It
must be challenging for you.

THAAL

Certainly more challenging than
resisting your gaze.

PUPPET SOLDIER

So you've figured me out? You're a
force to be reckoned with. I ought
to be more careful around you.

THAAL

Caution cannot deter destiny.

PUPPET SOLDIER

You know the rhythm of wisdom and war, but lack the experience to garner victory.

(beat)

Just know this, before all is said and done, I will be adding you to my collection.

EXT. RIVER - DAY

An area just outside the Screaming Woods. The river stretches out to an unfathomable distance.

The mountains in the background look like they've been dipped in powdered sugar.

Ox stands by the river peeling his shirt off. He rolls his pant legs up to his knees and then gets into the river.

Steam erupts from the river. Soon it's boiling.

The fish jump out of the water and onto the grass in an ironic attempt to escape death.

Ox celebrates and goes to collect his bounty. Notices something in his peripheral.

He jumps into action, ready to fight for his life.

Apparently, it's not what he expected.

It's an old MAN, 60s, soldierly disposition.

Fearing having been discovered, Ox collects as many fish as he can in his shirt and runs into the Screaming Woods.

The Man shrugs and starts collecting some fish for himself, nonplussed.

EXT. ABANDONED CABIN - SAME

Ox, Sebastian, Mora, and Silos have taken up house at an abandoned cabin in the Screaming Woods.

Made of wood, weathered, sunken in roof, no windows. It's an upgrade from their home in the Oraro Ghetto.

The group is sitting around a fire just outside the cabin, eating the fish Ox caught from the river.

SEBASTIAN

(to Ox)

Did he say anything to you?

OX

(to Sebastian)

Nothing. He just stared at me. I didn't even hear him coming.

MORA

He could be one of those things.

SEBASTIAN

(to Mora)

No way. They only come out at night.

(beat)

Haven't any of you noticed?

They consider it and silently agree with Sebastian.

Long pause.

SILOS

(nonchalant)

I saw Betty today. She was fighting.

All eyes on Silos.

SEBASTIAN

(to Ox)

We have to save her.

OX

We have no supplies. No weapons. Almost no food. We don't even know where to look.

SEBASTIAN

We can search!

Sebastian pulls out his wand.

SEBASTIAN (CONT'D)

We have a dragon, and I have my father's wand.

OX

Exactly. Your *father's wand*. What happens if it rebounds on you again?

(MORE)

OX (CONT'D)

I don't have a wand, Silos and Mora
don't know how to use combat magic.
We'll be dead in minutes.

SILOS

No, stop fighting! We have to wait!
He'll tell you how to get her.

OX

(to Silos)

Who?

SILOS

The man from the river. He has a
big house with pictures that can
show you the way.

(beat)

But we still can't help her. Only
the other man. The heart of the
desert.

Beat, then Silos rests his head on Ox's shoulder.

SILOS (CONT'D)

(to Ox)

Always remember that love will keep
you warm.

SUNSET - CONTINUOUS

When they realize the sun is setting, they put the fire out
and rush inside leaving behind all of the uneaten fish.

INT. ABANDONED CABIN - CONTINUOUS

There are wooden planks thrown about the cabin, an old brick
oven, and an old mattress laid out on the floor.

They shut the rickety door.

Ox and Sebastian barricade the door with some of the wood.
Then lay down against the wood, reinforcing the barricade
with their body weight.

Silos and Mora lay down on the mattress.

LATER -

They're asleep.

A sudden, shrill shriek wakes them all. There's movement outside the cabin.

Mora cries; Silos holds her.

SILOS
(concerned; to Mora)
The smith's boy. He has a secret.

A soft knock at the door -

LITTLE GIRL (O.C.)
Open.

Another knock, harder this time.

LITTLE GIRL (O.C.) (CONT'D)
Open.

Silence.

LITTLE GIRL (CONT'D)
(irate)
Let me in!

The Little Girl rams the door with the force of a full-grown man.

Ox and Sebastian can barely keep the door closed.

BANG. BANG. BANG.

The door jumps, almost popping out the hinges.

A hysterical laughter travels about the darkness outside.

Whatever is outside is running around the cabin, laughing.

Silos continues to mutter about the smith's boy, scaring Mora even more.

There's another knock. Further up this time, at a height no human can reach.

BANG. BANG. BANG.

At this point, the Little Girl sounds more like a beast having a go at imitating a human -

LITTLE GIRL (O.C.) (CONT'D)
Open.
(beat)
It.

She scratches at the door, crying softly.

They proceed to wait out the torment, like one would a storm.

SUNRISE -

All is quiet.

Everyone has either fallen asleep or passed out from fatigue.

There's a knock on the door.

No one wakes.

Another knock, firmer this time.

The person, or thing, on the other side, decides to push its way into the cabin.

A head pokes in. It's the Man from the river.

MAN
(like a drill sergeant)
Wake up!

Our group shoots up, ready to fight for their lives.

The Man gets a kick out of this -

MAN (CONT'D)
(laughing)
Rise and shine, strangers.

OX
(to Man)
Who are you?

MAN
(to Ox)
They call me the Medicine Man. I
heal people, save lives. That kind
of thing.
(beat)
And, now, I'm here to save all of
you.

EXT. TRAIL - DAY

The Medicine Man is leading the group up a winding trail overlooking the river where Ox first saw the Medicine Man.

The group is weary of the Medicine Man, but desperate enough to trust him.

MEDICINE MAN

You'll all be safer at my place.
There's enough room, food, and
clean water for you all.
(looking at Ox)
There's a shower too.

OX

(to Medicine Man)
Why are you doing this?

MEDICINE MAN

Because if I don't, you'll die.
(beat)
They call this place the Screaming
Woods. After staying in that old
cabin, I'm sure you know why.

EXT. SCREAMING WOODS - SAME

They're deep in the woods.

As they further along, they start seeing corpses of an unknown, humanoid cryptid with bleach-white, hairless skin laid out in the woods.

SEBASTIAN

(ref: cryptids; to
Medicine Man)
What are they?

MEDICINE MAN

If you haven't seen one, I'm sure
you've at least heard one.
(beat)
Those are skin-walkers. Or were
skin-walkers. Feisty beasts. Soon
as gut you as look at you. And if
you lock eyes with one, it'll be
able to transform into you quicker
than I can snap my fingers.
(beat)
I kill the ones that come too close
to my place and then drag the
bodies out into the open. They
don't like the smell of their own
dead.
(no reply; rambling)
Of course, you can't kill them with
a blade. Or a gun.

SEBASTIAN
(to Medicine Man)
Magic?

MEDICINE MAN
(to Sebastian)
Maybe. But I'm no wizard.

SEBASTIAN
So, how do you kill them then?

MEDICINE MAN
Poison.

Sebastian and Ox look at each other.

The Medicine Man suddenly stops walking.

The group stops and backs away from the Medicine Man.

OX
(to Medicine Man)
Why are we stopping?

MEDICINE MAN
We're here.

The group looks around.

OX
There's nothing but trees here.

MEDICINE MAN
Great observation.
(pointing forward; to Ox)
You first.

Ox watches the Medicine Man suspiciously. Reluctantly marches forward, and then disappears.

EXT. MEDICINE MAN'S SANCTUARY - CONTINUOUS

Ox has passed through an invisible barrier.

We're still inside of the Screaming Woods, but everything seems much brighter.

Ox marvels at the scene, and for the first time hears the chatter of the birds passing through the trees.

In the distance is a cottage that is a far cry from anything we've seen in the city. Thatched roof, handsome brickwork, sturdy-looking porch, and a flower garden.

Sebastian, Mora, Silos, and the Medicine Man pass through the barrier one-by-one.

Silos and Mora are enamored by the landscape. They start running around, playing and laughing.

Sebastian and Ox remain suspicious.

SEBASTIAN
(to Medicine Man)
I thought you said you weren't a wizard?

MEDICINE MAN
(to Sebastian)
I'm not.

The Medicine Man starts walking toward the cottage.

The group follows.

OX
(to Medicine Man)
Then how do you explain...
(looking around)
All this?

MEDICINE MAN
(to Ox)
An old friend did me a favor.

The Medicine Man laughs.

INT. COTTAGE - LATER

The cottage is fully furnished, painted and decorated with a level of detail reminiscent of royalty more so than an old, poor recluse.

Ranch-style, six bedrooms, two bathrooms. A filled bookshelf spans the entirety of the living room.

The Medicine Man's cottage is immaculate, in the sense that there's no hint of filth. But every table is cluttered with maps, open books and shuffled manuscripts.

Ox, Sebastian, Silos, and Mora are sitting on the living room floor eating soup in silence.

The Medicine Man is sitting by the window smoking pipe.

SEBASTIAN
 (to Medicine Man)
 So that barrier keeps out the skin-walkers?

MEDICINE MAN
 (looking out the window)
 Amongst other things.

SEBASTIAN
 That's why you had us go in first.

MEDICINE MAN
 Precisely. I knew you weren't one of them, but I had to be certain you weren't another sort of thing I should avoid.

Beat.

SEBASTIAN
 You live here by yourself?

MEDICINE MAN
 You ask a lot of questions for someone who hasn't even told me their name yet.

SEBASTIAN
 Oh, I'm sorry.
 (beat)
 I'm Sebastian. These are my cousins, Ox, Silos, and Mora.

MEDICINE MAN
 And what brings you, kids, all the way out here?
 (no reply)
 Probably what drives all folk in this direction. You're running from something.
 (no reply)
 Of course, most of the ones that even make this far down die within a few days. You, lot, have been here how long? A month at least.
 (no reply; to Ox)
 I'm not surprised. I saw what you did the other day in the river. You're wizards, aren't you?

Ox rolls up his sleeve to show Medicine Man his tattoo.

OX

We had to leave the city. It isn't safe for us anymore.

MEDICINE MAN

It never was.

(beat)

This country itself isn't safe for anyone. Best thing you can do is to go anywhere else but here.

(beat)

When did you all come here?

OX

About five years ago.

MEDICINE MAN

If you can survive five years in this country, you can live a lifetime anywhere else in the world.

OX

We can't leave.

MEDICINE MAN

What's holding you?

SEBASTIAN

We have to save someone.

The Medicine Man takes a big toke.

MEDICINE MAN

You all don't seem like the fighting sort.

(beat)

Who's the lucky lady?

OX

Our cousin.

MEDICINE MAN

How do you know if she's alive?

SILOS

(jovial; to Medicine Man)

I can see her! I see a lot of things. But not like how I see you.

(cupping his hands over his eyes)

I have to do this. Or look out a window, and then I see things. Things that people don't see yet.

(MORE)

SILOS (CONT'D)

My sister is like me too. She can tell you things from a long time ago.

MEDICINE MAN

(to Silos)

You're a very smart boy!

Silos giggles.

Sebastian checks out the books on the shelf. He notices many of the books are on magic, spell casting, alchemy, etc.

MEDICINE MAN (CONT'D)

What do you see in my future?

Silos cups his hands over his eyes again.

SILOS

I see...

(beat)

A monster. Different from the screaming ones. It's going to come here to talk to you when we leave. I wish we could stay but we have to go so Mora can find the heart of the desert.

SEBASTIAN

(changing the subject)

For someone who isn't a wizard, you seem to have a lot of books concerning magic.

MEDICINE MAN

I'm a well-read man, and my interests vary.

The Medicine Man takes another big toke.

MEDICINE MAN (CONT'D)

Right, so you know your cousin is alive. You could probably find her too. But obviously, if she needs saving, as you said, then she's gotten herself captured by something, or someone, terrible. And how exactly do you plan on liberating her?

(no reply)

(MORE)

MEDICINE MAN (CONT'D)

I won't advise you to leave your cousin in the claws of your enemy, but I also won't advise you to knock on Death's front door so frivolously.

OX

Then what would you advise us to do?

MEDICINE MAN

I was like you once. Quick to the draw. Ready to take on the world with only the absurd notion that I alone could change everything backing me. I was born in a sanctuary, just like this one, created and ruled by a powerful wizard who combined old magic with the new. We were fed, and mostly happy. But I wanted more for my people and this country of ours. So, I joined the army thinking I could climb my way to the top and change the system from the inside.

Beat.

OX

And what happened?

MEDICINE MAN

People died. Friends, family.

(beat)

When the power of the many is stolen and distributed amongst the few, mutual understanding and compassion toward our fellow countrymen deteriorates. That is the problem with Petrapolis' government. It's an archaic system you can't defeat with honor and rational discourse. It can only be brought down with blood and gold.

(beat)

Wherever your cousin may be, there is no doubt in my mind that our government has had a hand in her detainment. If you want to save her, whatever you know must be forgotten. Whatever morals you have must be discarded. Fight dirty.

(MORE)

MEDICINE MAN (CONT'D)
 Don't hesitate to kill anyone who
 stands in your way, and just maybe
 you'll stand a chance at saving
 her.

OX
 We're not murderers.

MEDICINE MAN
 If you don't become a murderer,
 then you'll be murdered.

OX
 I don't care. I'll do whatever it
 takes to save her, but I won't
 stain my soul.

MEDICINE MAN
 Would you sacrifice your life to
 save hers?

OX
 Yes.

MEDICINE MAN
 You must know well the value of
 what you intend to sacrifice for it
 to be considered a sacrifice.

INT. PRISON - DAY

ANA'S BEDROOM -

Despite the shoddy appearance of the prison's exterior, Ana
 appears to be sleeping in the lap of luxury.

Mint green walls, immaculate smoke-colored carpet, and
 furniture fashioned by the most talented hands in Petrapolis.

Full bed, complete with nightstands and a small sofa at the
 foot of the bed.

Ana is lounging on the sofa.

A knock at the door.

Ana opens the door. It's Dari.

ANA
 Hello there!
 (kissing Dari's cheeks)
 So glad to see you!

DARI

I'm sure. To what do I owe the
pleasure of being invited to
your...

(looking around)

Sanctuary.

ANA

It's been at least a full day since
I first had the guards give you a
ring. You must have been awfully
busy.

DARI

Some of us have to work. Something
you aren't quite acquainted with
from what I gather.

Ana pokes his head out into the hall. Claps his hands.

A female soldier enters the room with a tray of tea and
cookies.

Ana and Dari take a seat on the sofa.

The soldier kneels and holds the tray up for Ana and Dari.

ANA

(taking his cup)

It's Earl Grey, hun. Have a cup.

DARI

I'll pass.

Ana shoos the soldier away.

The soldier leaves, quietly closing the door behind her.

DARI (CONT'D)

(ref: female soldier)

I see you've trained that one well.

ANA

Not much of a fighter that one. But
she keeps the tea flowing just how
I like it.

(beat)

Now, down to business. Have you
heard from the good doctor? Our boy
has woken up.

DARI

Ah, yes. *Your* boy that you're so
fond of.

(MORE)

DARI (CONT'D)
(counting on her fingers)
What number are we at now?

ANA
I'm sure you'll find the tally on
your headboard. No shame in living
through another's conquests.

Polite laughter.

DARI
He's probably not very pleased with
you. The way you're gallivanting
about this place crying wolf every
other month.

ANA
Well, I'm sure he'll be pleased to
know that his search has finally
come to an end.

DARI
I'll be the judge of that.

Dari gets up and heads for the door.

DARI (CONT'D)
Where is he?

ANA
Level one.

As Dari's exiting, Ana blows her a kiss.

ANA (CONT'D)
Nice seeing you again. Love what
you've done with your hair!

As soon as Dari closes the door behind her, Ana gags
dramatically, rolls his eyes and then lights a pink
cigarette.

AXL'S CELL -

Axl's cell is on LEVEL 1, a floor above the entrance, where
the noobies are broken, and the chronically naughty are
punished.

The cells are concrete rooms caked with filth, feces and
blood with heavily rusted iron gates.

There are two guards for every five cells, heavily armed with
guns and wands.

Axl is in his cell, chained to the floor. Filthy with grime. Body littered with bruises.

He stares out into the darkness in silence.

Suddenly, we hear heels striking the floor.

Dari comes into view. She has a scimitar strapped to her side.

Dari stops in front of Axl's cell. Sizes him up.

Dari snaps her fingers and a guard immediately comes and unlocks Axl's cell door.

Dari enters the cell.

DARI
(to Axl)
So, you're the flavor of the month.
I don't see anything special about
you.

Dari examines his teeth, like one would a show dog.

DARI (CONT'D)
(to Guard)
Has he been dosed?

GUARD
(to Dari)
Yes, ma'am.

DARI
(to Guard)
Get him collared; I want to
introduce him to the rest of the
pack.

A Guard comes in and happily secures Axl in a spiked harness with a chain leash.

Dari walks Axl out of the cell.

GUARD
(to Dari)
To the chambers?

DARI
(to Guard)
No, I won't waste my time breaking
this one.
(beat; ref: Axl)
This is Ana's flavor of the month.
(MORE)

DARI (CONT'D)
I'll let him get a quick bite to
eat, and then I'll introduce him to
our favorite prisoner.

The Guard dons a wicked smile.

CAFETERIA -

The cafeteria is an empty room without any chairs or tables.

Instead, there are five wooden feeding troughs.

The soldiers on cafeteria duty line the prisoners up against the walls, on their knees, and then fill the troughs with an odd, meat-colored slime from filthy buckets.

Once the troughs are filled, the soldiers move out of the way and allow the prisoners fight amongst themselves to eat from the troughs.

Dari walks Axl into the cafeteria. Finds an empty spot in the center of the cafeteria. Snaps her fingers at a nearby soldier.

The soldier salutes her.

DARI (CONT'D)
(to Soldier)
Give him a bucket to himself.

The soldier brings a bucket over.

Dari kicks the bucket over. The slime floods the floor.

DARI (CONT'D)
(annoyed; to Axl)
Eat.

Axl digs in. Gags frequently.

Dari kicks Axl into the slime.

DARI (CONT'D)
You don't want to eat?

Dari pulls at Axl's leash. *Get up.*

Reluctantly, Axl obeys.

As they're walking toward the door, Axl spots a familiar face across the room.

Betty.

AXL
(to Betty)
Bet?

Betty looks at him. Stands up. She can't believe her eyes.

Axl pulls away from Dari.

BETTY
(crying)
Axl!

Dari yanks on Axl's leash until he stops struggling to get away.

DARI
(sadistic; to Axl)
Oh, so she's something special to you.
(ref: Betty; to Soldiers)
Grab the girl. To the chambers with her.

BETTY
(aghast)
Please, no!

They grab Betty. She resists, but she's no match for them.

A male inmate runs over to help Betty.

Dari releases Axl. Unsheathes her scimitar, and then proceeds to behead the male inmate without haste.

Axl runs toward Betty.

Dari grabs him by the neck and choke-slams him to the floor. She holds her sword up high, aiming for his arm.

As Dari goes in for the kill, an invisible force stops her from striking Axl.

Dari looks around the room.

CLOSE ON Thaal peering into the cafeteria from the door.

Axl recognizes Thaal but doesn't say anything for fear of Dari's reaction.

DARI
(ref: Betty; to Soldiers)
Dose her and get her out of here.
(to Axl)
As for you...

SHOWERS -

A small room with multiple shower heads and drains in the floor.

A dank, black mold has taken hold of the room.

Axl is being scrubbed clean by two soldiers while Dari watches.

They wash him down twice. Turn the showers off. Dry him off with a towel.

They rub him down with lavender oil and then pat him dry again.

They walk him, naked, out of the showers.

STAIRS -

Spiral, concrete stairs so covered with filth they've become black, contrasting with the off-white walls.

Axl is shaking like a wet dog. He trips.

The soldiers force him to stand up.

DARI (CONT'D)
(to Soldiers)
The next time he trips, shoot him.

They continue.

LEVEL 5 HALLWAY-

This particular hallway is immaculate.

Axl leaves behind black footprints as they lead him to a door.

Dari unlocks the door. Opens it, and then kicks Axl inside.

OAK'S CELL - CONTINUOUS

This "cell" is as large as Ana's bedroom.

No furniture. No windows. Just a MAN meditating in front of a Vitamin D light bulb on the floor.

This man is OAK, 60s, salt-n-pepper hair, one false eye.

Dari stands on the threshold of the door, smirking.

DARI (CONT'D)
(to Oak; ref: Axl)
This is your new toy. Don't break
this one.

Dari exits. The soldiers close the door.

Like a beaten puppy, Axl cowers in the corner.

To Axl's horror, Oak's false eye pops out of his skull and floats freely in the air.

The eye turns so that the side with the iris is pointed at Axl.

OAK
I see you.

CHAMBER -

The chamber is much cleaner than the rest of the prison, apart from the corpses sprawled about every which way.

The chamber has torture racks, tiger benches, Syrian torture boxes, water boarding tables, an iron maiden, and a treasure chest.

A naked and drowsy Betty has been strapped to one of the racks.

Ana enters the chamber. Skips past the corpses and approaches Betty, fluttering his eyelashes coyly.

ANA
(playful)
You've been a bad girl.

Betty mumbles. The drug she's been injected with is taking its toll on her.

ANA (CONT'D)
They called me because, apparently,
I'm the only one who can handle
you.

Ana saunters over to the chest. Opens it.

It's filled with multiple torture devices...heretic forks, lead sprinklers, neck devices, straps, knives, etc.

Ana plucks out a standard knife. Cuts his finger on it. His wound bleeds black blood.

Ana licks his finger and the knife clean and then returns to Betty's side.

ANA (CONT'D)
Now, I like you, but I can't have
you causing any trouble.

Ana teases Betty with the edge of the knife.

ANA (CONT'D)
I heard they put you into the iron
maiden the other day. Tried to kill
you, they did.

Ana makes a long cut on Betty's thigh.

ANA (CONT'D)
But, from what I hear, when they
opened the door to collect your
body, the spikes had been bent. And
you, my dear, were very much alive.

Ana cuts her chest. Digs the point of the knife into her flesh.

ANA (CONT'D)
Such a feat is praiseworthy. Me
thinks you deserve a proper title
to celebrate.

Ana licks the bloody knife.

ANA (CONT'D)
I can't think of anything. Maybe
I'll just call you *the* Iron Maiden
and be done with it. But, I'd have
to see you work your magic first-
hand before you get your title.

Ana digs the knife into her shoulder.

ANA (CONT'D)
I want to see what you can do!

INTERCUT BETWEEN AXL AND BETTY -

- UNDERLINE will indicate BETTY scene.
- Oak's voice remains constant throughout.

Oak stands up and inches toward Axl.

OAK
What sort of boy are you?
(licking his lips)
The unbreakable sort?
(no reply; loud)
Answer me.

AXL
(frightened)
Please!

OAK
There it is. Now I know you're not
a mute.

Oak studies Axl's face.

OAK (CONT'D)
I wonder, black-eyed boy, what have
you seen with those eyes?

Oak is close enough to Axl that Axl has to turn his face to
avoid smelling his rank breath.

Oak caresses Axl's cheek.

Ana pulls the lever on the torture rack as Betty screeches
like a dying animal.

OAK (CONT'D)
Were you of that unfortunate lot
that watched their families and
friends die in front of them? Their
blood running cold onto the ground.
Their cries for help to whichever
god they chose to believe in,
ignored, as per usual.

We HOLD ON Ana's face, smugly smirking.

OAK (CONT'D)
Or are you the monster that skulks
through the darkness? The faceless
killer dumping corpses in rich soil
meant for new life.

Oak leans in even closer. Licks Axl's face.

OAK (CONT'D)
(whispering into Axl's
ear)
I am the beast inside all us
madmen. That which scratches at the
lock on the cage.
(MORE)

OAK (CONT'D)
That which howls in the night after
tasting warm blood.

Oak kisses Axl's cheek.

OAK (CONT'D)
I so very much want to kill you,
black-eyed boy. But meat should be
tenderized before it is filleted.

Oak's floating eye glows.

A psionic construct made of solid light appears around Axl,
securing him to the wall.

Oak turns Axl's face toward him. Then he kisses Axl on the
mouth.

Betty stops shrieking for a moment. She appears to be in a
trance.

Ana is intrigued. Releases the lever.

Axl is being flung around the room by Oak's solid light
construction. Slams him to the floor, then the ceiling. Rinse
and repeat.

A metal chain slithers across the floor of the chamber.
Launches itself at Ana and wraps around his neck. Strangles
him until he passes out.

Axl is a bloody a mess. He appears to be dead.

Oak stands over him, smiling.

Betty struggles to get out of the rack.

Ana stands up, which shocks Betty.

ANA
Surprise!
(beat)
It'll take more than that to kill
me.

Ana holds Betty's head so that she's forced to hold eye
contact with him.

ANA (CONT'D)
Listen to my voice.

Betty relaxes. Stops struggling.

Ana's pupils dilate. In turn, Betty's pupils dilate, indicating that she's under Ana's hypnosis spell.

ANA (CONT'D)
Can you hear me?

BETTY
(monotone)
Yes.

ANA
What is your name?

BETTY
My given name is Nereyda. My
surname is Rodriguez, but I
readopted my mother's maiden name
after my father's death.

ANA
And what is that name?

BETTY
Ardenhart.

Ana is surprised to hear that name.

ANA
When I beckon, you obey. When I
slither into the bowels of your
mind, you surrender. A great power
sleeps within you, and we will use
that power to stain the world red
with the blood of our enemies.
(beat)
You are hereby stripped of your
name and history. From this day
forward, you are the iron maiden.

BETTY
Yes, Master.

LEVEL 5 HALLWAY -

Dari is standing by Oak's cell door, listening to Axl's torturous screams.

The screams stop.

Dari cracks a smile. Starts walking down the hall.

Thaal appears at the end of the hall. Meets her halfway.

They both stop, face-to-face.

THAAL

Don't bother running; you won't escape. Don't waste your time calling for help; no one will hear you.

DARI

You know me. I'd never do either of those things.

THAAL

Good. That will make this easier. I don't particularly like killing women when they're begging for their lives.

Dari flashes a sadistic smile, unsheathes her sword and charges at Thaal.

Dari takes a swing at Thaal. He dodges.

Dari kicks Thaal's abdomen, knocking him to the floor.

Dari goes for a deadly stab, but the sword is blocked by an invisible force.

Dari attempts to cut through the invisible force, and her scimitar bends, rendering it useless.

Dari pulls a small dagger out of her pant leg. Attempts to stab Thaal again with the same result.

Thaal is calmly lying on his back, smiling.

THAAL (CONT'D)

Your biggest flaw is that you value brute strength above all else. Your single-minded fury has pre-ordained your downfall.

An invisible force picks Dari up and suspends her mid-air.

Dari's eyes turn black (sclerae included). Struggles to escape the invisible grip that holds her.

THAAL (CONT'D)

(getting up)

Had you learned to observe and analyze on any level beyond rudimentary counting, you'd have known you were no match for me.

DARI
The King will have your head for
this, you fucking traitor!

THAAL
Fuck the King.

Thaal pulls a wand out of his shirt. It looks like Axl's
wand's base form.

THAAL (CONT'D)
No one will find your body. Your
disappearance will remain a mystery
to all but me. I am next in line to
become the director of this prison.
And my first act as the new
director will be to devise an
investigative division of soldiers
tasked with uncovering the truth
behind your disappearance. And they
will fail, of course.

Thaal presses his wand against Dari's throat.

THAAL (CONT'D)
If you have any last words, speak
them now.

Dari spits at Thaal.

Thaal's wand transforms into a broadsword, killing Dari as a
result.

OAK'S CELL -

Oak is still standing above Axl, waiting to see a sign of
life.

Keys jingling. Thaal enters the cell.

OAK
I think I killed him.

THAAL
How unfortunate.

Oak turns around, shocked.

OAK
Who are you?

THAAL

I am Thaal Ardenhart, the Director
of Prison Five.

OAK

(skeptical)

I've never seen you before.

Oak creates a barrier of solid light around him. Shoots light
bullets at Thaal.

The bullets are blocked by an invisible barrier around Thaal.
Wherever the bullets strike purple cracks appear, making
Thaal's barrier semi-visible.

Stalemate.

OAK (CONT'D)

You've wandered your eyes. That's not
very traditional.

THAAL

(ref: Oak's false eye)

I didn't peg you for a
traditionalist.

OAK

This is a new world we live in.
Survival trumps tradition.

(beat)

Still, it's very risky. One
rebounded spell, and you'd die
instantaneously.

THAAL

If one uses only the preferred
element, the risk of rebound is
lessened to below zero percent.

OAK

How blessed you are to have
mastered the art of shield making.
You're a true Ardenhart, without a
doubt.

THAAL

I'm not familiar with your
discipline. Who are you?

Axl wakes up. His sclerae, like his irises, are now black.
Holds his hand up.

There's some activity in Thaal's pants. It's Axl's wand.

Thaal fishes the wand out. Aims it at Oak, and releases it.

The wand flies through Thaal's and Oak's respective barriers and into Axl's hand.

Axl's wand transforms into its scepter-form. Axl stabs Oak in the leg with the crescent end of his wand.

Oak howls in pain and then goes silent. He's paralyzed.

Oak's eyes roll to the back of his head. His false eye falls to the floor. His light construct fades. And then he collapses.

Long pause, then Axl's eyes revert to normal.

AXL
(exhausted)
Thank you.

Axl looks at Oak's corpse.

AXL (CONT'D)
(disturbed)
What am I?

THAAL
Exactly what you were born to be.
(beat)
Where did you get that wand?

AXL
A man gave it to me.

Axl tries to get up. Fails.

AXL (CONT'D)
Help me!

Thaal goes over to Axl. Kneels. Pats his head.

THAAL
You were condemned to death the moment you stepped foot on these foreign lands. If I helped you live today, you would only die tomorrow. No matter where you go, you won't be able to outrun fate.

Thaal kisses Axl on the forehead.

AXL
Thaal, what are you--

An invisible force flips Axl onto his belly. Pins down his arms and legs.

THAAL

I alone will bear the weight of
this sin, if it means you'll pass
quickly instead of living a life
filled with pain.

AXL

Thaal, please!

Thaal presses his wand against Axl's back.

THAAL

Let our ancestors witness my
transgression, but only the God
below may weigh my golden heart and
judge the stains on my soul.

Thaal's wand transforms into its sword form, cutting straight through Axl's heart.

Death throes. A final croak. Axl Ardenhart is dead.

Thaal's wand reverts to its base form again.

Thaal grabs Axl's wand and walks out of the cell without showing any emotion.

Long pause, then Death saunters into the cell, smoking a black cigarette.

INT. PURGATORY

An all-encompassing, white nothingness.

Axl's spectral figure is surrounded by chaos bleached white.

In front of him is a large, metal door, ajar.

Behind him is an identical door, wide open.

Axl looks at the Ajar Door:

- Nothing waits behind this door except darkness, as far as Axl can see.

He turns around. Looks at the Wide Open Door:

- We see Death, standing over Axl's and Oak's corpses.

- Death waves at him, nonchalant.

Axl walks over to the Ajar Door. With all his strength, he pries it open.

As the Ajar Door opens, the Wide Open Door closes in relation to how open the Ajar Door is.

Axl manages to completely open the Ajar Door. Looks inside:

- Darkness, save for a small, white light somewhere in the distance.

Axl turns to look back at the other door:

- Death peeps through the crack of the door. Gives him the finger.

Axl faces the darkness before him. Steps inside.

The darkness takes him. Swallows him whole, as though it has a will of its own.

INT. DARKNESS - CONTINUOUS

Axl glides through the darkness without effort. It's like a warm embrace.

The white light in the distance grows larger and brighter as he nears it.

We inch forward. Closer and closer, until we

FADE TO WHITE -

INT. UNDERWORLD - CONTINUOUS

FADE IN -

A room with grey marble floors and black walls.

Stained glass depicting "The Fall of Man" and the "War in Heaven" span the entirety of the room's ceiling.

In the center of the room is an active fountain featuring black lotus flowers.

A MAN, 30s, black hair, black suit, sits on a throne of gnarled wood and bones positioned behind the fountain.

Further behind him are two large doors on either side of the throne. One black and the other red.

Axl and the Suited Man stare at each other.

AXL'S HALLUCINATION:

MALE VOICE (O.C.)
 (hushed; to Axl)
 Arioeh.
 (no reply; louder)
 That is the name I give to you, my
 son.

Axl looks around the room trying to pinpoint the source of the voice.

MALE VOICE (O.C.) (CONT'D)
 (ear-splitting scream)
 Arioeh!

Axl realizes the voice is coming from above:

There is a BLONDE MAN, 30s, very long hair, crucified to a cross on the ceiling.

The Blonde Man rips his hand from the cross.

Black blood drips onto Axl's forehead.

His hand stretches to an inhuman length. He's reaching for Axl.

Axl's sclerae instinctively turn black. Then he reaches out to the Blonde Man.

The interaction between the Blonde Man and Axl harkens to Michelangelo's "The Creation of Adam."

CUT TO:

INT. PRISON - DAY**OAK'S CELL -**

Death is chilling out amongst all the gore and death, still smoking.

Ana enters.

ANA
 Someone's been busy.

DEATH
 (whimsical)
 Don't look at me.

Death checks his hand watch.

DEATH (CONT'D)
Guess I better get moving.

ANA
Won't you stay for tea?

DEATH
Give me a rain check.

INT. UNDERWORLD

Just as Axl and the Blonde Man are about to touch, Axl snaps out of it -

END HALLUCINATION.

Axl is still facing the Suited Man.

The Suited Man stands.

SUITED MAN
Welcome.

AXL
What is this?

SUITED MAN
The entrance to the Underworld.

The Suited Man walks toward the fountain.

SUITED MAN (CONT'D)
Here and now, I will decide whether you will go to a place of eternal life or one of eternal punishment. I will weigh your heart on the scales of justice, and I will study the stains on your soul.

The Suited Man fills a cup with the water from the fountain.

SUITED MAN (CONT'D)
You will drink from the fountain of knowing. This divine drink will undo the locks on your consciousness so that we may together explore your past and expose the stains on soul.

Axl inches toward the man. Stops. Looks up.

The Blonde Man is nowhere to be found.

SUITED MAN (CONT'D)
Only then may you--

AXL
Where is he? The man with the
blonde hair.

SUITED MAN
(angry)
I see. You're one of his spawn.
He went by many names in the past.
The Morning Star. Light-bringer.
Father of Demons.
(beat)
Today, we call him the Great
Pretender, the usurper sent by a
foreign God to undermine the rule
of my father who may not have been
the first, but was the best ruler
of the Underworld.
(beat)
Just as men do, Gods come and go.
The hierarchy of power shuffles
about, as it should. It is only
when the Gods themselves take on
the qualities of men as they play
the game of divine politics that
chaos is born.

Death appears behind the Suited Man.

DEATH
(to Suited Man)
This one has to go back.
(beat)
He's the one.

The Suited Man pours the water back into the fountain.

SUITED MAN
What a shame.

AXL
Who are you people?

SUITED MAN
(ref: Death)
This is my consort, the primordial
deity, Death.

DEATH
(to Axl)
Charmed.

AXL
(to Suited Man)
Who are you?

SUITED MAN
I have many names. But you don't
have enough time left to hear them.

Axl starts to sink into the floor.

AXL
(panicked)
Wait! I'm not ready!

Axl's lower body has completely disappeared.

AXL (CONT'D)
Please, tell me if my mother beyond
one of those doors!

Only Axl's head is visible.

SUITED MAN
You'd have to find out for
yourself.

Axl disappears.

INT. PRISON - DAY

OAK'S CELL -

Ana stands over Axl, waiting.

A long pause, then Axl wakes with a harsh cough. His mouth is
caked with dry blood.

Ana smiles.

ANA
Morning, sunshine!

Axl tries his best to crawl away from Ana. His wounds have
healed, but he's still weak from hunger.

ANA (CONT'D)
Don't leave! The fun hasn't even
started yet.

Ana grabs Axl by the hair.

ANA (CONT'D)
 You know, for a minute there I
 thought I was fucked.
 (sing-songy)
 But now I can get you all cleaned
 up for your big date! Aren't you
 excited?

EXT. PRISON - SAME

A girl with an ax strapped to her back and a third eye crudely drawn with blood on her forehead marches toward the prison gates with an entourage of three Royal Soldiers.

The Royal Soldiers wear the standard Petrapolian Army uniform, but with gold stripes on their left shoulders.

This is ADONIS, short, buzz-cut, cheekbones of a goddess.

The Royal Soldiers are:

A) Sergej - A hulking, Polish strongman.

B) Z - A slender, Asian man with the demeanor of a highly disciplined soldier.

C) Sledge - A lanky guy with a war hammer strapped to his back.

A group of prison soldiers open the gate door for them.

Adonis watches the prison carefully.

SERGEJ
 (to Adonis)
 What is it, your Highness?

A man speaks through Adonis.

ADONIS
 (Man's voice)
 Something powerful awaits us.

Z touches Adonis' shoulder.

Z
 (to Adonis)
 Are you ready, your Highness?

ADONIS

(Man's voice; to Z)

No. I want to see every cage, every facet of this place. I wish to sample every flavor of the fruits of my labor.

Z

(bowing)

As you wish.

As the group enters the prison, the soldiers inside kneel before them.

EXT. MEDICINE MAN'S SANCTUARY - MONTAGE

A) Sunrise - Ox's burly silhouette comes out of the cabin. He stretches. Watches the sun rise.

B) Morning - Ox warms up with push-ups. He starts traditional, and then transitions into one-armed push-ups.

C) Noon - Ox does pull-ups on a tree branch. Overhanded, wide grip.

D) Day - Ox is taking a nap in the grass. Snoring loudly.

E) Ox is bench pressing Silos.

F) Ox and Sebastian are sparring.

G) Later - Ox and Sebastian are napping, back to back, in the grass.

END MONTAGE.

INT. COTTAGE - DAY

LIVING ROOM -

The Medicine Man and Mora are sitting across from each other at the table reviewing a map of Petrapolis.

The Medicine Man points to a dot on the map -

MORA

Battle of Trytos. Fifty-nine dead.

MEDICINE MAN

Soldiers or civilians?

Mora concentrates. No dice.

MEDICINE MAN (CONT'D)

Both.

The Medicine Man points to another dot on the map -

MORA

Battle of the Dead Tip. Twenty-six dead.

(beat)

Soldiers and civilians?

The Medicine Man nods. Points to a different dot -

MORA (CONT'D)

Battle of the Desert Town of Kheeter. One-hundred-eighty-two dead.

(disbelief)

Civilians.

MEDICINE MAN

That's right. It wasn't a battle. It was a massacre.

(beat)

All three of these places were the bases of those who rebelled against the King. Well, that was a few Kings ago--

MORA

King Brightworth II.

MEDICINE MAN

That's right.

(beat)

It was a time when men, wizards, and other creatures lived side-by-side in relative harmony. The King and the Oracle ruled together. The Oracle with wisdom and logic, and the King with an iron fist. You might ask yourself "What could go wrong with a system built with wisdom, logic, and strength?"

(beat)

Well, there was nothing wrong in the city that was named after the island. There, wizards and gesangoj, our word for "non-magic person," lived together in harmony.

(MORE)

MEDICINE MAN (CONT'D)

Those who couldn't provide for themselves were given whatever they needed by their magical neighbors. And those peculiar wizards with no talent for magic worked alongside their non-magic neighbors without a problem.

(beat)

But, outside the city is where the troubles started. The other three States on the island were independent of the crown. And the most skilled wizards ruled over the towns and cities in their states like Kings themselves. Unlike the city, the poor either starved or were used in other ways. Those who had no one who would come looking for them were often taken in the night and used as ingredients for dark magic. The three minor States themselves were always at war with one another, fighting for power and spilling blood with no regard to the value of life.

(beat)

But one man changed everything. He called himself, Ariocho. When he rose to prominence, he said simply, "I was a peasant boy born to a whore in Kheeter."

(beat)

You see, his mother was sacrificed to perform a spell that started a drought, killing all the crops in Kheeter that year. Having had his mother taken from him as a boy, he swore vengeance on the dark wizards ruling the lands. In his later years, he rallied together the poorest and the richest of non-magic men to take down those wizards that tormented them. And they did.

(beat)

They stole their crowns of iron from their cold, dead bodies and smelted them into arrowheads tipped with gold, which they used to execute any wizard who dared to stand against them.

(beat)

Kheeter fell. Dead Tip fell.

(MORE)

MEDICINE MAN (CONT'D)

And Trytos fell last, giving Kheeter control over the majority of the island. His political opponents called him Arioch the Conqueror, King of Poor Men and Broken Toys.

(beat)

Now, the King and the Oracle had remained mostly neutral throughout all this because the southern cities were granted their independence by King Brightworth I. But when Arioch the Conqueror declared war on the City of Petrapolis, they refused to sit idly by and allow the false King to sack the city. They sent him a letter by pigeon, with only a single sentence written on the parchment.

(beat)

"Come within ten miles of the City, and all your men will die."

(beat)

Legend has it that after reading it, Arioch used the paper to wipe his ass. Then, in just a few weeks, Kheeter and his ten-thousand strong army marched onward to the City. As far as they were concerned, the victory was already theirs.

(beat)

And, then it happened. The Oracle met Arioch and his army ten miles outside of the city with just Petrapolis' champion, Juraad the Great, to accompany her. The way the story goes, before Juraad could even unsheathe his sword, the Oracle had wiped out Arioch's entire army with just a single spell. Ten-thousand men erased from history with just a flick of the wrist. Then they took the false King Kheeter to face the judgment of the one true King of the island.

(beat)

"You will face a punishment far worse than death," the King said. "All the lands you have conquered will turn to waste. All the gold you have pilfered will turn to brick.

(MORE)

MEDICINE MAN (CONT'D)

And you will live on forever to watch all that you've sacrificed be all for naught."

(beat)

The once lush metropolis of Kheeter was turned into a desert. The once fertile lands of the Kingdom of Isle were turned to clay and filled with mist, becoming the Dead Tip. And Trytos, once again, fell last. A magnificent forest Kingdom was invaded by man-eating monsters, becoming what we now call the Screaming Woods. Some even say that the monsters were the soldiers in Ariocho's army. Twisted by dark magic, becoming what we call "skin-walkers."

Mora is amazed by the tale. She touches the map. Drags her finger from check mark to check mark.

MORA

And that's why they put these barriers up? To keep out the monsters.

MEDICINE MAN

(nodding)

There are sanctuaries like this one all over the island.

We can hear Ox and Sebastian outside sparring.

MEDICINE MAN (CONT'D)

(ref: Ox & Sebastian)

They've been at it all day.

(beat)

I'm going to see what all the fuss is about.

EXT. MEDICINE MAN'S SANCTUARY - SAME

The Medicine Man comes out the cabin with a sword.

He sneaks up on Ox. Pokes him in the back with the sword.

Ox tenses up.

Sebastian moves out of the way.

MEDICINE MAN

Never fear death. He pines for you
and your enemies embrace all the
same.

Ox and the Medicine Man spar.

At several instances, the Medicine Man could have killed Ox
with ease.

MEDICINE MAN (CONT'D)

You're too hasty. Try using your
brain more.

Ox gets angry. Lunges at the Medicine Man.

The Medicine Man hits him on the head with the hilt of his
sword.

Ox hits the ground. He's fuming.

The Medicine Man points the sword at Ox's face.

MEDICINE MAN (CONT'D)

This sword has seen many battles.
Some I've lost, many I've won.

(beat)

It's yours if you can disarm me
before sundown.

Ox grabs the sword's blade, confusing the Medicine Man.

Before the Medicine Man can react, the blade turns cherry-red
with heat.

The Medicine Man jumps back, releasing the sword.

OX

(smirking)

I disarmed you.

The Medicine Man smiles. Starts laughing.

MEDICINE MAN

(re: sword)

Well, go on. Let's see you handle
it.

Ox gets up. Picks up the sword.

OX

He's beautiful.

MEDICINE MAN
Love at first sight.

Ox goes over to a nearby tree. Attacks it with the sword.
Cuts through it like butter.

OX
(ref: tree)
Whoa!

MEDICINE MAN
(impressed)
I take it you've never done that
before.

OX
I've never done anything like that
before.

MEDICINE MAN
(whimsical)
Some wizard you are.
(beat)
That's the purpose of the wand. To
draw out what sleeps inside, and to
pressurize the faucet of energy
that leaks out of you. To be able
to use magic freely without a wand
is an uncommon, but great gift
nonetheless. You don't have that
gift. That means you're the
underdog.

OX
A sword can't be a wand.

MEDICINE MAN
Says who? Stranger things have been
done.

The Medicine Man ruffles Ox's hair -

MEDICINE MAN (CONT'D)
(fatherly)
I'm proud of you.

Ox is shocked by the Medicine Man's kindness. He smiles, on
the verge of tears.

EXT. MEDICINE MAN'S SANCTUARY - TWILIGHT

Ox and Sebastian are suited up and ready to head out.

Sebastian pulls Rys from his pant leg. Transforms him into his dragon form.

Mora and Silos are excited but frightened.

Medicine Man hands Sebastian a map.

MEDICINE MAN

I worked with the twins all night
to get a good idea of where you're
headed.

(beat)

You two ready?

Ox and Sebastian nod nervously.

Medicine Man hugs Ox and Sebastian.

MEDICINE MAN (CONT'D)

Come back to us. You hear me?

OX & SEBASTIAN

Yes.

Mora hugs Sebastian and Ox.

Silos hugs Ox. Then looks at Sebastian.

SILOS

(to Sebastian)

I love you, sun-gazer.

SEBASTIAN

I love you too.

Ox and Sebastian climb on Rys' back.

They wave goodbye as they take off.

Medicine Man, Mora, and Silos watch them until they're out of sight.

EXT. PRISON - DAY

There are more soldiers stationed on the prison grounds than usual. They mindlessly trot around.

Thaal is among them. He watches the clouds.

Rys comes into view. Rys hovers above the prison grounds.

The soldiers panic at the sight of Rys.

RANDOM SOLDIER 2

Snipers!

The snipers shoot at Rys.

The bullets are unable to pierce Rys' thick hide.

RANDOM SOLDIER 2 (CONT'D)

Maneuver twelve!

The soldiers on the ground form a human shield around the front door of the prison, four rows of five. They pull their wands out.

Thaal is in the last row.

The first row of soldiers cast a low-level wind spell. Combined, the soldiers manage to produce a powerful whirlwind able to disorient Rys.

The second row of soldiers whips up a flamethrower, engulfing Rys in spinning flames.

The third row of soldiers releases a frightening burst of lightning which coils around the spinning flames like a snake.

They hold this combination for as long as possible.

Eventually, the elemental spells dissipate.

Rys and the boys are unscathed. Protected by a spherical barrier with purple cracks running through it.

The barrier shatters, like glass.

Before any of the soldiers can resume their assault, giant holes appear in their chests, killing them.

Coated with blood, we can make out what killed them:

Psionic tendrils that are invisible to the eye, except when damaged or coated with something, linking back to a psionic barrier around Thaal.

The tendrils snake their way back into the barrier. Then the barrier fades away.

Rys breathes fire onto the sniper forts, completely incinerating them.

Rys descends onto the prison grounds.

Ox and Sebastian dismount Rys. Stare at Thaal with utter shock.

OX
(to Thaal)
We thought you were dead.

THAAL
And here I am.

They run to Thaal and bear hug him.

The emotional moment is cut short by the wails of a surviving sniper.

The sniper crawls out of the wreckage of one the sniper forts. His body is burnt almost black.

The Burned Sniper inches toward Ox, Sebastian, and Thaal.

Just as he gets close to them, the Burned Sniper passes out.

Ox and Sebastian are struck with guilt.

THAAL (CONT'D)
(stern)
You two shouldn't have come here.

OX
(to Thaal)
Why are you here?
(ref: Thaal's uniform)
Your wearing the soldier's uniform.

SEBASTIAN
(to Thaal)
You're not one of them are you?

THAAL
No, of course not.
(beat)
I'm here on behalf of the Oracle.
She sent me to gather information
on the atrocities being committed
against our people that have fled
to this country.

OX
(excited)
Then you're a knight. You're
nobility now.

THAAL

Yes.

(to Sebastian)

Just like your father.

Ox and Sebastian kneel and bow to Thaal.

THAAL (CONT'D)

Get up, both of you. This isn't the place for that. You're here to save Betty aren't you?

The boys nod.

THAAL (CONT'D)

How did you find this place?

SEBASTIAN

We had help.

THAAL

I was hoping to get her out of here by myself, and I am glad I now have two powerful wizards by my side.

Sebastian and Ox are beaming.

THAAL (CONT'D)

But I also didn't need two more people to keep alive.

(beat)

You're already here. So we must act now and leave this place as soon as possible.

Ox and Sebastian look at each other.

Thaal starts for the prison--

OX

We have to tell you something.

(beat)

Axl is dead.

Thaal doesn't turn around.

OX (CONT'D)

(confused)

Right after that night, we landed here. We moved to the Capital and--

(choking up)

To make a long story short, he was shot to death in the streets of the City.

THAAL

We have to go. Now.

They head for the prison doors.

Thaal stops half-way.

THAAL (CONT'D)

You two, go ahead. I'll catch up.

Thaal kisses Ox and Sebastian on their foreheads.

THAAL (CONT'D)

Kill anyone who approaches you.

Sebastian digs his wand out. Shows it to Thaal.

SEBASTIAN

I still have it. My father's wand.

THAAL

Don't use that wand unless you have to.

Sebastian shrinks Rys, so that he can fit through the prison doors.

SEBASTIAN

My mother... Did she survive?

THAAL

Go, and save your cousin. We'll talk about that another time.

Ox, Sebastian, and Rys head into the prison.

THAAL (CONT'D)

You can come out.

The Burned Sniper wakes up. Crawls over to the dead soldiers. Digs into the pocket of a soldier and pulls out a pack of cigarettes.

They're pink. He lights one. Smokes it.

BURNED SNIPER

I didn't know you could sense me.
Aren't you full of surprises?

THAAL

The watcher has become the watched.

(beat)

Why didn't you act?

(MORE)

THAAL (CONT'D)

I'm sure things would've gone differently if you had.

BURNED SNIPER

Things are more fun this way.

(beat)

I always knew you'd turn traitor. All that power you keep tucked away and out sight, and absolutely no ambition to climb the ladder. It was obvious.

THAAL

And, yet, you let it all unfold without so much as lifting a finger. Won't your future Queen be upset with you?

BURNED SNIPER

I'm not afraid of Lily Law.

(beat)

And what difference does it make? All of the hauls of late have just brought in trash. Everyone in this place can die. Except for the Iron Maiden. She's my favorite.

Thaal squeezes his wand.

BURNED SNIPER (CONT'D)

(cocky)

You know, if you're trying to be discreet, you shouldn't use your actual name.

THAAL

I'd rather not. I want everyone who stands beside you to know the name of the man who killed them.

The Burned Sniper laughs.

Thaal stands over the Burned Sniper, ready to execute him.

BURNED SNIPER

There's another layer to you. You're not just mommy's little pet. There's another side to you. Something invisible to the naked eye.

Thaal presses his wand against the Burned Sniper's neck.

THAAL

What makes you say that?

BURNED SNIPER

I've been playing this game for a long time.

Thaal's wand transforms into its sword form, beheading the Burned Sniper.

INT. PRISON - DAY

LEVEL 1 -

As Ox and Sebastian enter the prison, they are struck with the rank odor of Level 1.

The emaciated prisoners reach out to Ox and Sebastian through their cell gates, begging for help.

Ox, with his sword burning hot, slices through the cell gates, one by one freeing them all.

SEBASTIAN

(to Ox)

We can't waste time here.

Ox continues freeing the prisoners.

OX

(to Sebastian)

We can't just leave them.

The prisoners clamor to get out.

Inside the last cell is a feeble, old man. Ox frees him -

OX (CONT'D)

(to Old Man)

Come on!

The Old Man takes his time getting up.

OLD MAN

I'm an old man not long for this world. I'm in no rush.

Sebastian shrinks Rys again, and then the trio head up to the next level.

The Old Man watches them. We see now that his pupils are dilated.

LEVEL 2 -

A replica of LEVEL 1, but somewhat cleaner.

Ox and Sebastian continue setting more prisoners free.

A band of soldiers wielding wands comes rushing onto Level 2 from Level 3.

Fully realizing they have the element of surprise, the Guards unleash a barrage of elemental attack spells, fire lightening, wind, at them.

The spells are blocked by a psionic wall.

Thaal appears behind Ox and Sebastian.

A second wall of spikes crashes into the soldiers from behind, smashing them against the first wall and killing them.

The second wall only becomes visible once coated in the soldiers' blood.

THAAL

We haven't any more time to spare.

OX

(to Thaál; irate)

We can't just leave them here to rot. These are our people.

Beat.

THAAL

Very well.

Thaal closes his eyes. Concentrates.

All the cell gates are sliced open by an invisible force.

The prisoners run for their lives.

THAAL (CONT'D)

Now, let's go.

ANA'S BEDROOM -

Ana snaps out of a trance. He's out of breath.

Surrounding him are Adonis and the Royal Soldiers.

Axl is chained to the wall.

ANA

(to Adonis)

We don't have much time. We need to
get the boy and go.

ADONIS

(ref: Axl)

I haven't even decided if he's
worth taking back to my father.

(ref: Royal Soldiers)

Whatever is coming our way, I'll
have them deal with it.

Ana gets in Adonis' face.

ANA

Don't be impetuous, little girl. We
can't afford to lose him.

They hold eye contact.

ADONIS

Don't bite the hand that feeds you,
old man.

Adonis backs away from Ana.

ADONIS (CONT'D)

(Man's voice)

Enough! Test him and be done with
it!

(Adonis' voice; sheepish)

Yes, father.

Adonis' eyes turn black (sclerae included). Turns to Axl.

ADONIS (CONT'D)

(to Axl)

Don't die.

Adonis rips off the chains pinning Axl to the wall. Throws
Axl to the floor.

Axl stands to fight.

Adonis charges at him. Picks him up by the neck and throws
Axl through the door.

LEVEL 5 HALLWAY - CONTINUOUS

Axl shakes it off. Runs down the hall, trying to escape.

Z teleports himself and his fellow Officers in front of him, blocking his path.

Axl turns around.

Ana and Adonis are at the other end of the hall.

Adonis saunters toward him.

AXL
(to Adonis)
What do you want from me?

ADONIS
(Man's voice)
We are here to judge you.

Adonis wields her ax.

ADONIS (CONT'D)
(Man's voice)
Whether you live or die today will
be decided here and now.

Adonis points her ax at Axl.

The ax's blade dislodges itself from the handle and shoots across the hall.

Axl catches the blade.

Adonis is impressed. She recalls the blade, and the ax reassembles itself.

Adonis lodges her ax into the wall, choosing to continue the fight hand-to-hand.

They're almost evenly matched, but Axl's inexperience is obvious.

Axl winds up on the floor. Adonis goes to finish him off with a lethal kick.

Axl rolls out of the way. Notes the heavy damage inflicted on the floor.

Axl goads Adonis into continuing to attack him while he's on the floor.

Adonis takes the bait. Goes for another kick. Misses.

The floor caves, taking Axl and Adonis with it.

LEVEL 4 HALLWAY -

LEVEL 4 is where the soldiers reside. There are rooms, rather than cells, like on LEVEL 5.

There isn't a single guard in sight.

Ox and Sebastian are making their way toward the stairs at the end of the hallway when Axl and Adonis fall through the ceiling.

Ox and Sebastian can't believe their eyes. Axl, likewise, is shocked to see them.

Once Adonis brushes off the fall, she continues her assault.

At this point, Adonis is toying with him.

Axl manages to create some space between them. He's almost finished.

The Royal Soldiers, with Ana in tow, teleport behind Adonis.

ADONIS (CONT'D)
(ref: Ox and Sebastian; to
Royal Soldiers)
Eliminate the intruders.

Z attempts to teleport to Ox's side of the hallway but winds up next to Adonis instead.

Confused, Z reaches out. Touches something solid.

An invisible wall divides the hallway in half, limiting Z's range and separating Axl from his foes.

Adonis punches the wall but fails to break it.

Thaal appears behind Axl.

Axl turns to look at him. He's furious with Thaal but appreciative of his saving him.

Axl's wand worms its way out of Thaal's shirt.

Axl catches it and shoots Thaal a nasty look.

ADONIS (CONT'D)
(to Thaal)
Traitor!

Stalemate.

THAAL
(to Axl, Ox, Sebastian)
Head for the stairs.

ANA
(to Z)
Z, dear. Won't you come here?

Z teleports to Ana.

ANA (CONT'D)
(to Z)
Let's go get our little friend.

Z teleports himself and Ana away.

Just as Axl, Ox, and Sebastian are about to reach the stairs,
Z, Ana, and Betty come walking through the door.

They're now surrounded on both sides.

Betty is still under Ana's hypnosis. She's wearing the
Petrapolian Army uniform and her pupils are dilated.

	OX	SEBASTIAN
Bet!		Betty!

ANA
(ref: Betty's uniform; to
Thaal)
Do you like the new look? I for one
am loving it.
(to Betty)
Go on dear.

Betty draws a gun. Starts shooting at Axl, Ox, and Sebastian.

The bullets hit a barrier that Thaал erected without anyone
noticing.

Eventually, she stops pulling the trigger and the bullets fly
out of the barrel on their own.

Then, while shooting, the gun floats out of Betty's hand.

When the clip is empty, the gun itself breaks down into crude
bullets which are launched at the barrier.

The bullets drill into the barrier but are unable to pierce
it.

OX
 (to Betty)
 Betty! What are you doing?

ANA
 (to Ox)
 She can't hear you, darling.

Ox bangs on the barrier.

OX
 (to Betty)
 Betty!

THAAL
 (to Ox)
 There's no point in yelling.
 (ref: Ana)
 That man's speciality is hypnosis.
 She's his puppet now.

ADONIS
 (Man's voice; to Thaal)
 Give us the boy, and you can have
 the girl.

ANA
 (ref: Betty; to Adonis)
 Aww, but I like this one.

AXL
 (to Adonis)
 What do you people want with me?

ADONIS
 You should be honored to have been
 chosen!
 (ref: wizards)
 You'd be better off with us than
 with them! Do you know how many of
 our kind has been killed by them in
 the name of whatever god they fancy
 at the time?

AXL
 "Us?"

ADONIS
 (to Axl)
 Half-castes.

SLEDGE
 (to Axl)
 Mutts.

ADONIS
(to Sledge)
Bastards, even.
(to Axl)
As no magic-born of any dignified
pedigree would ever wed our impure
mothers.

AXL
(confused)
I don't understand.

Sledge's eyes turn black.

SLEDGE
(to Axl)
Do you know what you are?
(ref: Himself & Adonis)
What we are?

ADONIS
(to Axl)
We're lower demons. The offspring
of those with tainted human blood.

SLEDGE
(to Axl)
Magic-born fathers and demon
mothers. Golden blood, burnt black.

AXL
My mother was no demon.

SLEDGE
(to Axl)
And your father?

Long pause.

AXL
(to Sledge)
My mother never said--

ADONIS
"My mother never said."
(to Sledge)
They never do, do they?

SLEDGE
(to Adonis)
It's not unheard of, for a magic-
born womb being able to house a
blood-burnt fetus.

ADONIS

(to Sledge)

But, still so very rare.

(to Axl)

That must be why you're so interesting.

SLEDGE

(to Axl)

Your parents must have had some pedigree to be able to spawn you. The right proportions on either side of your parentage, and volumes of great coincidences throughout their ancestral histories have all boiled down to this moment.

(beat)

Tell us your name.

ADONIS

(to Axl)

Your true name. That name that is whispered into your ear at night when all has gone quiet.

SLEDGE

(to Axl)

The name your one, true Father, gave you.

Axl is at first confused but has a light bulb moment.

AXL

(hesitant)

Arioch.

SLEDGE

(impressed; to Axl)

That is a fine name.

(beat; to Axl)

I am Salvador, but I am known as Sledge.

OX

(to Sledge)

I know you. You were the dueling champion of Aurates years ago. The only half-blood wizard to ever win the championship.

(disgust)

You were my hero.

SLEDGE

(to Ox)

Times have changed.

(ref: Adonis; to Axl)

This is Princess Adonis, first-in-line for the throne of Petrapolis.

(beat)

Axl, currently you are amongst some of the only people of your exact combination. We are the only ones who could ever truly understand you.

(beat)

Join us, Ariocho.

ADONIS

(to Axl)

The King is my father. I can persuade him.

SLEDGE

(to Axl)

That family you struggle so hard to protect, we will make sure that they want for nothing for as long as they live in this country.

Axl is seriously considering their offer.

ADONIS

(to Axl)

This offer will expire soon. Either you come of your own volition, or I'll drag you by your heels, but not without killing everyone who is dear to you on our way to my father.

SLEDGE

(to Axl)

The choice is yours.

Long pause.

ADONIS

(to Axl)

You're a fool--

SLEDGE

(Adonis)

Calm down for a second. This isn't an easy choice for him.

(MORE)

SLEDGE (CONT'D)

The prospect of abandoning his old life must be a difficult pill to swallow.

(to Axl)

I understand your position. You are in a foreign country with no land or title. Since the great fall of your homeland, you have had to struggle to survive, not only for your sake but for the benefit of those who depend on you. For a time, I was you. But where we differ is in my trust and loyalty to the King. With the King's favor comes certain freedoms. Namely, the freedom in knowing that the people you care for will forever benefit from your sacrifice so long as our King's reign lasts. For you to enjoy this freedom that I take for granted, you must be willing to sacrifice as I have. And even though our sacrifices may never be identical in measure, those people that depend on us will live long, happy lives because of them.

(beat)

Do the right thing, save your family.

EXT. PRISON - NIGHT

The sun is setting.

The prison is heavily damaged.

Scores of skin-walkers emerge from the surrounding woods.

Some of the skin-walkers are transformed into humans, and the rest are in their true form:

Ghastly, pale creatures with two sets of incisors encased in black gums. They have the eyes of snakes and the talons of birds. Their gait is unstable, forcing them to switch intermittently between a clumsy crawl and inhuman hobbling.

There is a Strange Girl among them. She'd be indistinguishable from the skin-walkers if it weren't for her distinctly human gait.

They pour into the prison grounds with unabashed savagery.

INT. PRISON - SAME**LEVEL 4 HALLWAY -**

Sledge is still waiting for Axl's answer, but Adonis has run out of patience.

ADONIS
Fuck this!
(to Sergej)
Smash through!

Sergej charges at the wall. Fails to break through. Continues attacking.

On the other side, all nearby metal is launched at Thaal's barrier by Betty.

Purple cracks begin to permeate the wall as the metal drills into the barrier.

OX
Betty, stop!

Ana laughs hysterically.

OX (CONT'D)
(to Betty)
Nereyda!

All the metal attacking the wall falls to the ground.

Betty's pupils return to normal. She looks around, confused.

BETTY
(confused)
Ox?

Ana is taken aback.

OX
Betty! We're here to save you!

Hordes of skin-walkers pour into the hallway on both sides and immediately go on the attack.

Ana resumes control of Betty. Betty decapitates five skin-walkers by molding loose metal into a scythe.

The skin-walkers' bodies convulse and spew black blood in all directions.

Betty fashions a sword for Z.

Z teleports about the hallway, stabbing as many skin-walkers as he can.

Sergej is using brute force to fend the skin-walkers off. With a single punch, he can cave their chests in.

Sledge uses his war hammer as a wand. By channeling fire magic into the metal, he can incinerate a skin-walker with a single strike.

Ox tries to break through Thaal's already damaged barrier to get to Betty.

Thaal grabs Ox. Creates a new barrier in the shape of a prism as the previous barrier dissipates.

Adonis, Ana, Betty, and the Royal Soldiers continue to fight off the skin-walkers.

Despite their efforts, the entire hallway fills with skin-walkers.

Sensing impending death, Sledge slams his war hammer onto the floor. A powerful flame erupts and quickly envelops the entire hallway.

The floors and walls begin to crumble. Then the entire prison collapses.

EXT. SCREAMING WOODS - SAME

The burning ruins of the prison are visible in the distance.

Ox is pummeling a dying Sergej, crying.

Sebastian lays on the ground unconscious.

Axl and Thaal are watching from the sidelines.

AXL
(to Thaal)
Why did you save me?

THAAL
Why wouldn't I?

Axl pushes Thaal.

AXL
Because you fucking killed me!

THAAL

I did what I did to keep you out of their hands. It wasn't to make you suffer, it was to spare you from a far worse fate.

Ox turns his attention to Axl and Thaal.

THAAL (CONT'D)

The real question is why are you alive?

AXL

Because--

THAAL

I won't bother trying to kill you again until I know the answer to that question.

Axl shuts up.

Sebastian stirs. Looks around. Checks his person.

Sebastian realizes that Rys isn't on his person. He frantically searches for him.

SEBASTIAN

Rys!

(louder)

Rys!

THAAL

(to Sebastian)

Quiet! You'll alert them to our position.

(beat; solemn)

The beast and our cousin are likely dead. If you don't want to join them on the other side, the time to run is now.

Ox stumbles over to Thaal. Punches him in the face.

OX

(to Thaal)

You let her die!

Ox grabs Thaal by the collar.

Sebastian readies his wand.

OX (CONT'D)
 (louder)
 You let her die!

As Ox is about to punch Thaal again, Sebastian aims his wand at him -

SEBASTIAN
 Jealousy!

A green light pours out of Sebastian's wand and envelops Ox and Thaal.

The light fades. Ox and Thaal fall to the ground, paralyzed.

In turn, Sebastian's wand hand is paralyzed by a partial rebound.

Axl and Sebastian collect Ox, and trot off into the woods.

Before they disappear, Axl glances at Thaal one last time. Almost saying goodbye.

CLOSE ON Sergej, who's now opened his eyes. His pupils are dilated.

Sergej coughs. Laughs.

Sergej manages to get up and hobble over to Thaal. Leans in close, holding Thaal's face so that their eyes meet.

SERGEJ
 I told you. Before all is said and done, I'd add you to my collection.

CLOSE ON Thaal's face as his pupils dilate.

DAY -

Ox, Axl, and Sebastian are just outside the Medicine Man's sanctuary.

OX
 (to Axl)
 This is it.

Ox attempts to usher Axl through the invisible barrier, but Axl is unable to pass through it.

OX (CONT'D)
 (to Sebastian)
 Why isn't it working?

Sebastian shrugs. Enters the barrier. Pokes his head out.

SEBASTIAN
It's not broken.

Ox enters the barrier.

Moments later, Ox returns with the Medicine Man in tow.

OX
(ref: Axl; to Medicine
Man)
He can't get through!

The Medicine Man sizes up Axl.

MEDICINE MAN
(to Axl)
What are you?

Awkward silence.

Medicine Man rolls up Axl's sleeves to look for his tattoo.
But Axl doesn't have one.

OX
(angry; to Medicine Man)
He's one of us! He's my cousin!

MEDICINE MAN
(to Ox)
This barrier was created to repel
evil. Whatever he was when you last
saw him has been replaced with
something else.

Ox punches a tree.

OX
That's a lie!

AXL
(to Ox)
It's fine.
(beat)
I can find my own way.

OX
(to Axl)
No. We're not about to leave you.
We came to this country together,
and we're fucking going home
together.

Ox unsheathes his sword.

OX (CONT'D)
(to Medicine Man)
I guess you'll want this back.

MEDICINE MAN
No. Keep it. It's yours.
(beat)
I'm sorry it had to be this way.

OX
Don't be. It was too good to be true.

MEDICINE MAN
I'll bring the twins and some supplies out for you all.

Medicine Man looks at Axl again. Then goes through the barrier.

SEBASTIAN
Where will we go?

Awkward silence.

LATER -

The Medicine Man returns with the twins. They each have a backpack full of supplies.

Silos and Mora are utterly shocked to see Axl, but they happily hug him.

MORA
(to Axl)
Where's Betty?

Axl, Ox, and Sebastian share a look.

Ox grabs Mora's hand.

OX
(to Mora)
We have to go.

MORA
What? Why? I don't want to go!

Ox drags Mora as she struggles to get away. Picks up Silos and trots off toward the trail.

Axl and Sebastian follow close behind.

Silos cries and screams uncontrollably.

Mora waves sadly at the Medicine Man.

MEDICINE MAN

Wait!

They stop walking.

Ox looks at the Medicine Man reluctantly.

The Medicine Man waves them over.

MEDICINE MAN (CONT'D)

(to Axl; ref: Ox)

I don't trust you, but I trust him.
And I know those two kids are safer
here than out there.

The Medicine Man and Axl shake hands.

While still holding his hand, the Medicine Man leads Axl into the sanctuary.

EXT. MEDICINE MAN'S SANCTUARY - SAME

The birds are chirping. Nearby deer are grazing.

Axl is in awe at the sheer beauty of the Sanctuary. He smiles.

DAYS LATER -

They're having a Last Lighting ceremony for Betty.

The Ardenharts are dressed in tailored hand-me-downs from the Medicine Man.

Ox carefully pinches out the candles, leaving the one in the center of the circle lit.

The Medicine Man prays.

LATER -

Axl and Ox are lying in the grass, still dressed in their funeral clothes.

OX

What's it like on the other side?

AXL

I didn't really get past the entrance, but it was cool.

OX

Oh.

Beat.

OX (CONT'D)

Do you think she's happy?

AXL

Maybe.

OX

I remember the first time I saw her. Grandmother summoned her and her parents to the mansion. She brought this crazy, white cat with her. They said she couldn't leave home without it.

(beat)

She was sitting outside in this long, flowing summer dress just watching the cat eat grass. She was beautiful.

(beat)

I think that's how I'll always remember. Just sitting outside as the sun sets, watching that cat eat grass. The wind blowing her hair. And that beautiful smile of hers.

(beat)

We weren't supposed to meet until later that night, but I wanted to talk to her. I just wanted to tell her my side of the story. The truth about me. And that it wouldn't be whatever she was thinking. That I was different.

AXL

Did you tell her?

OX

Eventually. But when we first locked eyes...

(beat)

I couldn't do it.

(MORE)

OX (CONT'D)

She was so happy about it. It wasn't at all what I was expecting.

AXL

It was all her mother ever dreamed of. I think that's where it came from. She was never able to marry into the senior family, so I guess she wanted to live out her dream through Betty.

(beat)

You definitely weren't her first pick, but close enough.

OX

I know that now. But, I was a child back then. And she was even younger. I didn't really know the ins and outs of it all. Grandmother had the servants raise me like any other child in Aurates. I wasn't ever really expected to marry and make an heir.

AXL

So what did you do?

OX

I just held her.

(beat)

I loved her Axl. In my own way.

AXL

She knew that. She loved you anyway.

OX

I wish I could have been more than what I am for her.

AXL

She didn't. She loved you for who you are, and so do the rest of us.

(beat)

Adopted or not, you're still part of our family.

Long pause.

AXL (CONT'D)

I never got the chance to tell you something.

OX
What's up?

AXL
Paris.
(beat)
She's pregnant.

Ox sits up, shocked.

OX
Seriously?

AXL
Yeah.

OX
Well, what are we going to do?

AXL
She's better off without me.

OX
Do you love her?

Beat.

AXL
We can't go back to the city.
They'll be looking for us.

OX
Let them find us then.
(beat)
They caused all of this. The King
and his men. They kill our people
with impunity. They lock us up in
prisons and experiment on us. They
force us to fight, and kill our
own. They killed Betty.

(beat)
I'm even willing to bet he had
something to do with the civil war
in Aurates. We can't just let him
get away with all of this.

(beat)
And what about Paris? It wasn't
exactly a secret that you two were
dating. What do you think they'll
do to her if she's pregnant with
your baby? The King is our enemy.
He's what stands between our family
and peace.

Beat, and then Axl's sclerae turn black.

AXL
Then we kill him.

INT. THRONE ROOM - DAY

Marble-clad topped off with white walls.

Statues line the walkway, which spans from the entrance to the throne itself.

The statues feature various gods, prophets and prominent political figures throughout the ages.

A MAN sits on the throne, which is made of white stone with gold veins.

This is KING BRIGHTWORTH IV, 70s, blind and paralyzed from the waist down. He's more bone than man, but can sit on the throne without trouble.

There are two royal soldiers guarding either side of the open archway which serves as an entrance and exit.

To the right is Titan, 15, wears a top knot.

To the left is Io, 20s. The only female royal soldier.

Ana comes through the archway. He's freshly showered and dressed in a pristine suit.

The royal soldiers bow to him as he passes.

We follow Ana as he marches down the walkway. Once he reaches the throne, he pauses and bows.

ANA
I found that package you were
looking for.

Ana snaps his fingers.

A soldier escorts Paris to the throne. She's trembling with fear, but there aren't any visible marks or bruises on her.

ANA (CONT'D)
(to Paris)
Speak, girl. Let your King hear
your sweet voice.

PARIS
(nervous)
Good afternoon, your Highness.

The King holds his hands out.

KING BRIGHTWORTH IV
Come to me, dear niece.

Paris steps forward.

The King rubs her abdomen. Presses his ear against it.

KING BRIGHTWORTH IV (CONT'D)
This one speaks in dark tongues.

SMASH TO BLACK.